

MISSION WITHOUT STRATEGY

The story of the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship,
Scott Depot, West Virginia

by

Oliver C. Hogue

MISSION WITHOUT STRATEGY

The unusual account of how one church is discovering
the fulfillment of mission through
obedience rather than methods.

by

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To

Everett and Opal Hogue

My Parents

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The celebrated author Richard Foster says that writing a book is best done in community. The community of faith at Scott Depot not only provided the support for the writing of this book but, also, the focus because they are central to its content. Undoubtedly this church is one of the most extraordinary church groups in all the world. I extol them for being an example of renewal in contemporary Christianity.

Specifically, I would like to thank Rod Taylor, David Anderson, Rodney Dunn, Kathy Hogue, Faye McComas, Robert Bowers and Reimar Schultze for their technical contributions. My deep appreciation goes to my wife Barbara for typing the first draft of the manuscript and for her constant encouragement and support. Special mention should go to my secretary, Sandra Chittum, for the long hours and days spent in typing and retyping as well as technical corrections.

PREFACE

The writing of this book illustrates its title perfectly. It is not something I planned or even wanted to do. However, when Dr. James Newby, Director of the Yokefellow Institute, shared with me that both he and Dr. Elton Trueblood wanted me to write a book about my ministry and the unusual congregation at Scott Depot, West Virginia, the Holy Spirit immediately confirmed that this recommendation was also the will of God. So it is at the direction of the Holy Spirit and through the encouragement of Dr. Newby and Dr. Trueblood that I have written.

My friendship with Dr. Trueblood goes back to the days of my graduate studies in Anderson, Indiana. A fellow student invited me to journey with him weekly to the Quaker school in Richmond, Indiana, and study under the famous philosopher. I enrolled in "The Philosophy of Religion" solely to meet the man who had motivated so many Christians through his writings. More than twenty years later, that association and friendship were renewed through a young man from the Scott Depot congregation who, while attending school in Richmond, described his home church to Dr. Trueblood as a working model of that outlined by him in his best known book, The Company of the Committed. Subsequently, I was invited by Dr. Trueblood himself to attend and to share my story in the last preaching workshop he ever conducted. At the close of my presentation Dr. Trueblood's associate, Dr. Newby, commented, "Oliver, what you have at Scott Depot is Quakerism." Dr. Trueblood, who had not said a word since he first asked me to share, spoke suddenly, "No, James, what you have at Scott Depot is not Quakerism but seventeenth century

Quakerism." It was and is the highest compliment the great teacher and writer could pay anyone. Central to seventeenth century Quaker thought and practice is the idea that true religion must be experiential and that worship is not the performance of a dead ritual, but genuine waiting on the Lord actually to hear and obey His voice.

Both Dr. Newby, in several visits, and Dr. Trueblood, in an exceptional visit to Scott Depot, were satisfied as to the report of the church being a working model of renewal and commitment. On the Sunday which brought both men to our services and to our home, Dr. Trueblood said to me, "It could be that this is the most vital, exciting fellowship that we know of in the nation."

While on vacation last summer, my brother and I stopped with our families to see the Newbys and Dr. Trueblood. As we were leaving, Dr. Trueblood addressed me with a directness that was both startling and encouraging. He said, "You have done a great thing for the Christian world by sharing how one church can be alive. You will remember that I said that, won't you?"

The book which follows is a sincere effort to remember those very important words.

O.H.

Scott Depot, West Virginia
Thanksgiving, 1986

FOREWORD

Christian thinking in the twentieth century has placed major emphasis on the Church. Understanding the obvious inadequacy of a merely individual religion, Christian thinkers have given careful attention to the question of what a true Church could be. More and more there has been constructive reference to the Church as a redemptive society leading to increased emphasis upon the ministry of every Christian. The Scott Depot experiment does not involve original or unusual thinking. In fact the principles are essentially those expounded in The Company of the Committed. What is unusual is the degree to which such principles are taken seriously and practically applied. This is important for it is demonstration that is most needed now. In the vivid words of Dr. Johnson, it is "much easier to design than to perform." Where are the actual concrete demonstrations?

Along with thoughtful consideration of what the Church could be and ought to be, there have been isolated experiments in which this creative thinking has been tested in practice. The most celebrated of these experiments, providing a laboratory test of the new ideas, has been that conducted by The Church of the Savior, in Washington, D.C. Small enough to be a manageable unit and carried out where any who are interested may observe, this experiment in the national capital has brought new courage to thousands who have feared that the great days of the Church were over. Readers were heartened, in 1966, when a book by Elizabeth O'Connor, entitled Call to Commitment was published by Harper and Row and quickly became a best seller.

What Elizabeth O'Connor did two decades ago, in Call to Commitment and the other books which followed in quick succession was to tell interested people that a truly caring Church was more than a dream. People were heartened when they learned that a revolutionary experiment had actually been conducted and that it had succeeded. One demonstration they said, is more important than volumes of speculation. They were not sure that the experiment could be repeated, but they were encouraged by the fact that it could be done at least once.

Now we have another experiment to report, conducted in a strikingly dissimilar location. It is a long way from the nation's capital to the area west of Charleston, West Virginia, along the C & O Railway, where the fellowship described in this volume has emerged. That a truly revolutionary Christian fellowship should appear in West Virginia seems to many people highly unlikely because West Virginia is generally perceived a depressed area economically. How, in such an area, could there be a fellowship so vital that it can afford to provide generous financial help to widely scattered needs? This is especially surprising in view of the fact that Scott Depot has thrived without national denominational assistance.

Scott Depot is a Christian Society which belongs consciously to the post-denominational age. Not sectarian in any way it includes people who have previously been members of a great variety of denominations, and is even friendly with Hebrew Congregations. As the fellowship is non-denominational, it is likewise non-community. With the employment of automobiles, people who assemble at Scott Depot can come many miles, several coming from Charleston, fully twenty miles away. Even more important is the fact that the Fellowship is not star-

studded in its leadership. It does not have even a touch of exhibitionism which marks the characteristic electronic church of our generation. The attendance at all gatherings is remarkably good, but nobody comes because Scott Depot has a famous preacher. In contrast, the visitor may be surprised that the voice of the pastor is never the only one heard.

What is the major secret of the emergence of a powerful fellowship in an unlikely place? There are, of course, many reasons for the evident vitality, but the chief reason seems to be the degree to which the people really believe something. They are believers who love one another and are deeply involved in one another's lives. They believe that God is, that He is like Jesus Christ and that He has a work for each to do. One result of such convictions is that, when the public gathering is over on Sunday morning, most of the people remain together for a long time. In this regard they are strikingly similar to the Church of the Savior in Washington. They do not rush off to their Sunday dinners, because they are interested in the lives of each other.

The people described in this book are not unusual people. They are not endowed with greater gifts than are others. They do not have an unusual faith. They simply take seriously what others claim to believe.

The following paragraphs about the fellowship have been produced by one of the members:

"The congregants at Scott Depot are unique in their devotion to God and in the way He has been able to bless them in experience and expression of Himself. The people meet for worship on Sunday mornings, Sunday evenings and Wednesday evenings. The attendance on Sunday evening and Wednesday evening is often nearly as large as on Sunday

morning. Several families travel for forty-five minutes in one direction to attend services three times a week just so they can be at a church where God is blessing. The level of commitment of the people is particularly demonstrated in their phenomenal giving to the church. A congregation of approximately four hundred people (two hundred adults) has given over one-half of a million dollars a year for the last three years. This does not include the support of a Christian school and day care center. The people are only average wage earners and several have been unemployed in recent years. The people, without demands or pressure, have endeavored to seek first the Kingdom and make God's work their priority. Many give twenty to thirty percent of their income. In addition to this, the people have spent hundreds of thousands of dollars in recent years for trips of spiritual mission to Israel and other countries. As much as anything else, the sacrificial giving of a fellowship of people may measure the treasure of their heart."

"The people have been willing to let their pastor be absent from services to carry out any spiritual assignments of ministry for which the Lord has guided him. In fact, the ministerial arrangement for the pastor is a good example of the vision of the people. The associate and assistant pastors manage the mechanics of the ministry so that Oliver Hogue can be free to wait upon the Lord in prayer, to study, to write, to visit at the Lord's leading and to prepare his heart for preaching and for equipping the people for their own ministry. The people have shared in the fruitfulness of this arrangement. They have heard a message of commitment to God and of unconditional love that has the glory of Heaven upon it. They are becoming a truly caring fellowship of joy and praise. Young people attend all three church services and

tells the story in the first person, as he rightly should, but the hope is that this aspect of the story will be quickly transcended. Christians have long engaged in testimony, but they have done so for a purpose, the enlargement of the Kingdom of Christ. That is why this book is now published.

D. Elton Trueblood

INTRODUCTION

You are about to read an unusual account the like of which you may have never read before. You are about to read an account of a church that is attempting a significant and bold experiment of faith and is discovering a mission so grand that even those who have given themselves to it are only beginning to comprehend the depths of its meaning. This spiritual mission has already touched the lives of many people and is unfolding to become the best and central intention of God for His Kingdom. If the church described in this account, with others like it, can be true to this purpose of God and challenge still more groups of believers to this divine intention, then this cosmic mission could herald the coming of God's redemptive grace in a powerful way to this world.

We live in a world of darkness that is looking for light, a world of despair that is looking for hope, a world of disillusionment that is looking for a possibility of meaning, a world that is crippled morally and creatively that is looking for healing and the touch of promise, a world of coldness that is looking for the warmth of true love. The hope of the world will be in the reality learned and the reality displayed by a people in touch with God. A people in touch with God and His will can cause a cataclysmic change in this world as the mighty work of the Holy Spirit is released through them to change the hearts of men.

I know. I am one who has been changed by such a work of God.

I had forsaken the way of the spiritual training of my childhood. I had rejected God and His help, and I was wandering in a barren land that had no answers. I was charging off in all directions looking for the sunrise. I had rejected the supernatural, but the natural world had left me empty, hopeless and lost. I was searching for truth, for a point of reference that would give life meaning, but without God there was nothing. I claimed to be an atheist and dedicated myself earnestly to the socialist cause. Philosophically, I was a materialist and a determinist, believing that man was a chance configuration of atoms. I felt that churches were a great hindrance to human progress, for if God does not exist, then religion was a waste of personal and social energy. Society should be restructured in socialistic fashion in order to provide some kind of efficient order and to best prevent extinction of the species. My definition of love was "an internal, chemical-hormonal reaction that is associated with external stimuli." But my mechanistic views left me with a meaninglessness that was inconsistent with the hope of my heart.

God showed such marvelous grace toward me when He reached right over my supposed atheism and adamant feeling against the Church and changed me with His love. God reached me through the love and joy and sincere devotion to God of the pastor and people of the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship. I could hardly believe it. Here, within and among this people, were a joy and a meaning for life that I could not explain away. Here was a genuine love which would not find fault or speak ill of me when I was not present. I remember when, after finally getting over some intellectual barriers, I came to a place of prayer. I hardly knew how to pray. I did not believe in God. I did not believe in

"sin." (There were only social norms by which we did or did not abide.) But I knew that I had been looking for what was true. I wanted what was real. What if there really were an infinite and yet personal God who was like Jesus and who cared for me? What if I could know Him and relate to Him daily? It could be the greatest discovery of my life. This would have to be the greatest, most wonderful fact of all of reality.

"Oh, God," I prayed. "I don't know if You are real or not. The Bible has meant nothing to me. But, God! Oh, God, I want what is real. I want what is real in my life. God, if You are real, take hold of me. Take hold of me!"

God took hold of me! He has never let go. The joy, the excitement, the wonder, the adventure of my discovery that day has never left me. The way has only grown greater in promise and more wonderful in experience.

My life was touched. My world was changed because there was a man, Oliver Hogue, and a fellowship of people who had given themselves in devotion to God. God, by the power of His Spirit, reached me through the love and commitment of this people. The work of change in my life had to be God's work through this little group who had been properly equipped by its pastor and had followed him in the ways of Christ. I had been unimpressed by the nominal Church. I was not even looking for an answer in Christianity. God loved me and transformed me through this fellowship that was fulfilling its mission in Christ.

Others, many others, as well, have had their lives changed by the reaching of God through this fellowship of believers. Monte had a reputation of being one of the meanest men in our local area. The army

could not change him. He went AWOL whenever he decided, no matter how many times they put him in confinement. He had been in jail on numerous occasions. These experiences could not change him. But then, one day in the fall of 1971, his wife somehow persuaded him to go to a special building campaign dinner of the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship. He had been there only a short while when he overheard Oliver Hogue, pastor of the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship, praise the Lord in appreciation for some little act of His grace. Oliver's joy and the joy and love of the people at that gathering got into his heart like an arrow. By Christmas of the next year, he had given his life to God. Monte is now one of the most kind and loving yet stalwart Christian men. By God's grace, he has never looked back. Bill had been ensnared by homosexuality and witchcraft. God has rescued him and is transforming him through the forgiveness and fellowship of this same group. He hopes to someday help others in their recovery. Don had searched in many places for peace, for love and for God, even spending some time in India and Nepal in the Peace Corps and considering the eastern religions. At the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship, he came to the end of his search. Several young people have been delivered from the drug culture to take a new direction with God. They have found in their communion with God something better than their drug experience. Lori was a young college student who was disillusioned with God and churchdom. She found hope once again in the love shown by Oliver Hogue and the commitment to God displayed by his congregation. Her changed and now radiant life has been instrumental in bringing many others to this fellowship and to Christ. Keith's past experience with ministers had not been good. He was bitter. He never intended to be a "church goer" again. Prayer was made on his behalf.

He came "just to see" one Sunday morning and was so overwhelmed by the love and presence of God that he could not resist. Now he speaks more often than most others about the importance of supporting God's equippers of the saints. The Doss family came to spare their children from the false promises of the world and dead religion. All of their children are now trusting God, and their oldest son is on the staff of the church. Jim is a recovering alcoholic. He is now on the Board of Trustees and an important leader of the congregation. Another man, Jack, worships regularly at Scott Depot. His tender spirit was nearly crushed in all other places. In this fellowship of love he has found a home and rest. Jeanne had never sung professionally nor had she ever taken singing lessons, but she found a melody for her heart at Scott Depot. Now, as church soloist, her beautiful voice has ministered to thousands around the world. Karen, a young person who was thrilled with her experience with God, testified excitedly to her piano instructor about the work of God at her church. Now that pianist, one of the very best, is the pianist at the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship. Sally's ability, along with that of her husband Richard and their children, has been important to the blessing and the witness of the outstanding music of this fellowship. Others could witness of marriages being restored and revived, of children and parents being brought back together, of husbands or wives being recognized as special and beautiful in new and wonderful ways to their spouses. Even as I have told a few of these blessed stories, I think of the Lewis, the Taylor and the Reaser families and scores of others too numerous to mention and of how God has worked in their lives. The accounts could go on and on of hearts being changed, hopes being restored and lives being made joyful and meaningful.

once again. These are real people with real problems; however, they have found a real God in a real fellowship of love.

God is wanting to work through His people in a redemptive way. He desires to reach the world and change it with His love. You will read in this book how Oliver Hogue and the people of the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship have been discovering the mission God has for His children.

The Scott Depot Christ Fellowship is a transdenominational fellowship of believers. The members come from many denominational backgrounds and various socio-economic levels. Though from various walks of life, the Holy Spirit has been able to bring together this people in a unique and increasingly unified fellowship.

The name first given to the Church at Pentecost was "the fellowship" (Acts 2:42 NIV). This earliest of Apostolic designations is one of the best descriptions of the Church of God universal of which the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship is just a small part. Since Christ is the Head of the Church, this church chooses to call itself Christ Fellowship. The doctrines held are those of orthodox, historical Christianity as stated in The Apostles' Creed. The fellowship seeks to be known, however, by love, demonstrated by a right relationship with God and fellowman thus fulfilling the words stated by Jesus: "By this all men will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another" (John 13:35). The Church emphasizes the cost of discipleship. Jesus said, "If any man would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me" (Mark 8:34). It is through the fellowship of the Holy Spirit that the Church becomes the lips and eyes, the hands and feet and burning heart of the Lord Jesus to reach all men.

The congregants at Scott Depot are unique in their devotion to God and in the way He has been able to bless them in experience and expression of Himself. The people meet for worship on Sunday mornings, Sunday evenings and Wednesday evenings. The attendance on Sunday evening and Wednesday evening is often nearly as large as on Sunday morning. Several families travel for forty-five minutes in one direction to get to worship services three times a week just so they can be at a church where God is blessing. The level of the commitment of the people is particularly demonstrated in their phenomenal giving to the church. A congregation of approximately four hundred people (two hundred adults) has given over one-half of a million dollars a year for the last three years. This does not include the support of a Christian school and day care center. The people are only average wage earners and several have been unemployed in recent years. The people, without demands or pressure, have endeavored to seek first the Kingdom and make God's work their priority. Many give twenty to thirty percent of their income. In addition to this, the people have spent hundreds of thousands of dollars in recent years for trips of spiritual mission to Israel and other countries. As much as anything else, the sacrificial giving of a fellowship of people may measure the treasure of their heart.

The people have been willing to let their senior pastor be absent from services to carry out any spiritual assignments of ministry for which the Lord has guided him. In fact, the ministerial arrangement for the senior pastor is a good example of the vision of the people. The associate and assistant pastors manage the mechanics of the ministry so that the senior pastor can be free to wait upon the Lord in prayer, to study, to write, to visit at the Lord's leading and to prepare his

heart for preaching and for equipping the people for their important ministry. The people have shared in the fruitfulness of this arrangement. They have heard a message of commitment to God and of unconditional love that has the glory of Heaven upon it. They are becoming a truly caring fellowship of joy and praise. Young people attend all three church services and comprise a large youth choir which has traveled to other states and countries to minister the grace of God. The fantastic ability of our music director and pianist to bring out the gifts in the people has been complimented by the anointing of the Lord on our adult choir and special music. From trying to take a sacramental view of the universe in regard to the arts and creative Christian living to trying to be careful in the little acts of kindness and consideration, the people are endeavoring to make the Kingdom of God the measure, the focus and the central experience of their lives. One family is now worshipping with this fellowship because, on a trip to Israel several years ago, they observed how the people were thoughtful to pick up the little pieces of paper from the bus after tours and from the floor after meetings.

God alone is to be praised for what He has been trying to do at Scott Depot. Oliver Hogue has been careful and persistent in his declaration that "God has done the work." The people are, by no means or measure, perfect in the absolute sense. But to some degree, they are endeavoring to love and follow God and to love one another. All the while an exciting discovery is being made and a monumental mission is being undertaken. This mission is being carried out in a universally applicable manner, the positing of which is the intent of this book. The church is still growing in grace and in the knowledge of the Lord

and has much more spiritual maturity to achieve. The enemy of love and oneness still fights and all the more as he sees his stronghold being threatened. Human weakness intrudes upon divine possibilities. The heart-cry of the pastor is a brokenhearted one for help from God because he and the people are still so far from God's perfect will.

God has been able to do an exemplary work at Scott Depot for a number of special reasons. Prominent among them is the fact that God was able to send the man He wanted to this church to equip and lead the people. Members of the congregation have recognized this and have responded by receiving the pastor as one sent by God. They are choosing to follow with him the way of Christ in growing trust and commitment.

I remember when I went to visit Oliver in his study shortly after my conversion. I had experienced such grace upon my life and such occasions of blessedness in communion with Christ that I was greatly moved with a love for God and with an excitement for His Kingdom. I desired to commit myself entirely to God and His purpose for my life.

Oliver was sitting on a folding, metal chair behind a utility table because the furniture for his new office had not yet arrived. When I entered, he arose and greeted me with love in his eyes. There was something more in his eyes, too. There was that inner fire of devotion to God that had so touched my life.

"Pastor," I said, "I want more of God. I want to know Him better. I want to commit my life to Him for whatever He wants for me. I have seen in your life a love for God that is like a consuming fire, and I have seen a desire to do God's will like no one else I have ever met. I want that kind of walk with God, that kind of communion with Christ."

I remember how Oliver looked long and lovingly into my eyes.

Finally, he said, "Rod, I sense that you are honest in your seeking. Come and go with me in this way of Christ. You can be with me any time, any where. Come into my office any time. Ask me anything you like. Observe my life and see if it is real. I am looking for the people for whom God is looking--a people to trust Him, love Him and do His will. Come and go with me."

I have. And, by God's grace, I have not been disappointed. As of this writing, I have been with Oliver Hogue more than fourteen years. I love him more, esteem him more highly than ever. Not only that, if it is possible, I am more excited about God and His Kingdom, more excited about being with Oliver and this fellowship at Scott Depot than when I began. I have found Oliver Hogue to be genuine through and through. I have found him to be a man who desires to do God's will more than anything else in the earth. I have found him to be a man who desires to love, appreciate and learn from men and women of God who, regardless of their church background, really know and follow the Lord. I have found him to be a man who is looking for anyone with a heart hungry for God and desiring to be fully His. He is one of the most loving men I have ever met, giving himself beyond the point of human strength to serve God's people. To Oliver, all else must become secondary to the single burning desire to be God's true servant. Everything must be brought into joyful submission to Christ and His will. I suppose that he may seem a little strange to some at times because of his unswerving disposition to do God's will and his determination to serve and to follow all of God's true servants, but men and women of the Spirit often appear that way to those whose home is not the Kingdom. I have observed Oliver in the private place, behind the scenes, while he was being

hated, maligned and when he had been the object of fierce, verbal and jurisdictional attacks; yet he was unchanging in his love. I have been with him in trying circumstances, severely hurtful or stressful circumstances. Even so, he did not deviate from God's will. As for me, I simply want to lock arms with him as he seeks his dream to find the men and women who hear God's voice and the people willing to do God's will.

Joseph Conrad in his Mirror of the Sea quotes a letter of Sir Robert Stafford who commanded a ship in Lord Nelson's fleet. Nelson had chased to the West Indies a fleet nearly twice the size of his own. Describing the desperate hardships of that daring adventure, Stafford wrote, "We are half starved and otherwise inconvenienced by being so far from port, but our reward is--we are with Nelson."

In this labor of love I have not been half-starved and, though it may appear that circumstances and situations are "inconvening," I can gladly say my reward is--I am with this man, Oliver Hogue, and with this Savior, Jesus Christ. William H. Danforth, founder and former chairman of Ralston Purina Company and well-known philanthropist, summarized a spiritual discovery of the missionary doctor Sir Wilfred Grenfell in his much-read book, I Dare You. Mr. Danforth wrote that "all spiritual adventure has for its foundation first the giving of one's loyalty to a living leader and then expressing it in knightly service." I feel as if I am on a great spiritual adventure.

Paul Tournier, a Christian psychologist, has said in his book The Adventure of Living that one of the basic needs of man is the need, the instinct for adventure. This is because God is an adventurous God. Adventure for adventure's sake without the goal of God has no meaning. It is like trying to bottle the wind. The adventure that comes with

commitment to the Christ, to the Kingdom of God and to God's servants is the adventure that fulfills the soul. Tournier says, "When you come into contact with a man who is deeply committed to adventure you become possessed yourself by the spirit of adventure; once it takes hold it does not easily let go." I have a hold on something and something has a hold on me. May we never let go.

I have found men committed to an adventurous God, and I have become possessed with the same adventure. I am thrilled. May my heart, which can be deceitful above all things, not deceive me from my life decisions of loyalty. May you catch this same spirit of adventure in commitment to God as you read this book.

I warn you. This unusual account of how God has helped Oliver Hogue and the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship may challenge some of your ideas about the mission and methods of the Church. This book will probably initiate either excitement or exasperation. Some who read this account may not understand or may not have had previous experience with two important dimensions of Oliver Hogue's commitment to God: firstly, his heartfelt appreciation and thoughtful submission to those whom he discerns have a vital and deep knowledge of God and, secondly, his emphasis upon actually being able to know the will of God. Objections to the first baffle me. If one has a yearning for God, that person wants to be where he can see God or sense His presence, that person wants to be where he can see his Savior in trueness. Men and women of God open to our view the heart of Him whom we so dearly love. I, for one, want to find every opportunity to look through the hearts and lives of others to God, most especially those who reveal Him best. Does it not seem somehow incongruous that though some travel great distances and

wait great lengths of time to show appreciation to a worldly entertainer, to the chagrin of no one, if someone puts forth effort to be with a person of God and shows appreciation to him, their actions are sometimes considered to be giving excessive attention to a mere human instrument? I know we must be careful not to give undue or improper attention to man, but we have gone deleteriously to the opposite extreme by not properly honoring those whom God would honor and, in the process, we have missed much spiritual blessing and direction for our lives. As for knowing the will of God, I find it strange that some believe that God can no longer speak to His children concerning His specific will. For one thing, to believe that God can no longer reveal Himself to us is unreasonable. If I can speak to God, surely He can speak to me. Surely prayer is not a one-way conversation, and God is not more limited than I. Central to our Christian experience is our relating to God, and communication is central to relationship. God is not dead nor silent, and He still reaches with loving care into our lives. That God cannot guide His children also appears to be unscriptural. The Bible is full of instances where God revealed His will to His servants. He revealed Himself to Adam, Noah, Abraham, Moses, David, the prophets and to the common Jewish and Gentile persons as well (even to an ass, I might add). As recorded in the New Testament, He spoke to the Apostles, a centurion and many others. If such a relationship were only for the Early Church and no longer is possible now, then maybe I could facetiously propose, knowing of course that there are other major issues involved, that we should consider the advantages of pre-Incarnation times, for at least God could speak then to His servants in a personal, specific way. To deny that God can guide those devoted to Him is also contrary to

experience, contrary to the experience of the saints in every century and contrary to my own experience, for God has been gracious and real in relating Himself to me in communion of His Holy Spirit and in communication of His promise and His will. However you might deal with these particular issues, I believe the challenge of this book, if received with an honest and hungry heart, can not only change your ideas about the Church's mission but can also change the earnestness of your aspirations after God. Your life and the spiritual life of your church could be transformed if a new vision could be achieved, a true vision of the call to commitment and what it really means.

If you have desired something more, something deeper than your present experience of God for yourself or your church, then I believe you will find in this book assistance to fulfill that desire. This is not just a book which presents some esoteric principles for your contemplation. This is an account of how a group of people and a pastor have endeavored to put into practice the divine mission of God.

In the second chapter of St. John we read that, after Jesus had performed a number of miracles, many people seemed to be quite excited. However, John informs us that "Jesus did not trust himself to them, because he knew all men . . . for he himself knew what was in man" (John 2:24,25). It is a very sad pronouncement, even sadder when we realize that the world still has seldom seen what God would do if He could find a people to whom He could fully commit Himself. God, since the beginning, has been looking for such a people. Jesus is looking for a people right now to whom He can trust Himself: a people who have a heart perfect toward Him, a people through whom He can manifest His love, demonstrate His power and accomplish His will. God knows every

heart. God can trust His Kingdom only to the pure heart, the rejoicing heart, the trusting heart and the obedient heart. God can trust His presence and power to only the heart emptied of self-interest. Where are the hearts so prepared for such a sacred trust? Where are the hearts that long to be the home of the living God? God has found so few to whom He can truly trust Himself. Oliver Hogue believes that there can be such a people in these last days.

In a world of sin and turmoil, the Body of Christ must grasp the imperative of truly having Christ as her Head. While the world waits for hope, love and real fulfillment in the embrace of a living God, the intended Body of Christ staggers acephalously, hideously, purposelessly first in one direction and then another while clutching to her shrouded and shrunken breast or raising aloft for mocked observation whatever banner she has for the moment borrowed from the world. Only when Christ is leading the Church, only when He is her life and first love can she offer a unique and sufficient answer for the need of the world. For the sake of Christ and His Body and His will being done in this world, I implore you to consider carefully the proposals of this book. No more fertile frontier for spiritual exploration could be presented to the desperately seeking, sincere souls of this century than that of a deeper and more vital experience of the presence and will of God. I invite you to read the following pages with the open mind and heart which are due such an important experiment in pioneering faith and spiritual mission.

Rod Taylor
Associate Pastor
Scott Depot Christ Fellowship

Chapter 1

In Search of a Man

Follow me and learn these things.

---Socrates

"Drop all plans and methods and wait upon the Lord." The voice was that of my closest friend and spiritual advisor, The Reverend Loran Helm. I had requested him to pray with me about a plan or method that would reverse the declining attendance at the services of the church of which I was pastor. I am just beginning to learn of the momentousness of his simple but profound reply. In his response was the answer not only for my own church but for every church of the Body of Christ. The impact and implications for a church that would actually put such convictions into practice are revolutionary. The church that relies not on humanly devised strategies but rather takes as its mission to wait upon God for His will begins a new and significant adventure.

My first year at Scott Depot had seen no growth in attendance at all; however, all of that changed after Loran Helm shared with me the revelation of the Holy Spirit while in the Holy Land in June of 1970. One beautiful day by the Sea of Galilee, I was telling him how the Lord had helped me to make this second trip with him to Israel in spite of much difficulty. I had just finished reviewing with him the fact that the church at Scott Depot had experienced no growth during my first year and that one minister had told me that the Holy Spirit would not be able to work there anymore because it was a "burned over field." My dear

friend looked at me and said, "Oliver, because you believed me in spite of the difficulty when God said we should take this second trip to Israel, the Holy Spirit witnesses that He is going to triple your ministry." (We had already gone to Israel just six months previously. We were then on our second trip, and I had completed only eleven months as pastor.) When I arrived home the building began to fill. Instead of a summer slump, we experienced revival. In approximately one year, one hundred sixty persons had made a profession of faith in Christ and one hundred thirty of those were baptized. God had done a great thing. For the next four years the growth spiritually, numerically and financially was astonishing. We purchased more land, built a new building, began a bus ministry and trained our teachers in soul winning and visitation.

However, after four years when the average attendance began decreasing and I requested him to pray, Loran Helm shared with me his conviction that the Lord wanted me to drop everything; all plans, methods and programs were to be laid aside. The Scott Depot Christ Fellowship was to wait upon God and to do only what He revealed. We were to have a mission without strategy.

The next few months were extremely difficult for me. To wait upon God sounded good, but actually to do it was like death. Often I found myself pacing the floor, torn between the desire to do something to save my ministry and the desire to heed the spiritual advice. My head knew the theology, but my heart did not quite trust that this would truly work. The carnal nature was determined to save itself if it could. If it had not been for my confidence in the servant of God, I could never have continued a ministry that has produced one of the most wonderful congregations in the world.

When one meets a true man of God, confidence in that man is indispensable for spiritual growth. The secrets of the Kingdom are given only to those whose integrity is absolute. The Apostle Paul wrote to the church at Corinth: "This is how one should regard us, as servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God" (I Corinthians 4:1).¹ Jesus said to those He had commissioned as His representatives: "He who receives you receives me, and he who receives me receives him who sent me" (Matthew 10:40).

Primarily, the key to the successes of the Early Church as well as her failures was her response, or lack of it, to the Apostle Paul. God gave Paul more vision and revelation than any of the other Apostles. The genius of Christianity is in her universal outlook. In Christ there is no Jew nor Greek, no male nor female, no bond nor free. All barriers have been removed so that there is one new person and all have access to God by faith. Paul received that revelation in three days while it took Peter much longer. Even though the Council at Jerusalem concurred with Paul, it seems obvious by their silence and their stipulations that they had reservations in saying that faith alone justifies man before God. Consequently, those less benevolent in attitude and with far less vision threatened the very essence of Christianity.

The thought and teaching rampant in some circles of Christianity, that Christians must not follow or imitate a man, is the exact opposite of that taught in Scripture. Furthermore, it defies reality. Paul spoke both the Word of God and explained reality when he

¹Unless otherwise stated, all Biblical references are to the Revised Standard Version.

wrote repeatedly be imitators of me (I Corinthians 4:16, 11:1; Philippians 3:17). Of course, it was sound counsel because Paul was following Christ. The necessity of following a man of God or men of God is a fundamental principle of finding and experiencing spiritual truth. Paul did not make himself exclusive even though his revelation was greater than that of others. To be exclusive would have been to divide Christ. In fact, he wrote to the church at Thessalonica: "For you yourselves know how you ought to imitate us . . ." (II Thessalonians 3:7a).² The point is that following the men of God is essential to unity of knowledge and fullness of Christ. Paul explains in the letter to the Ephesians:

²According to a theological word study presented by Gerhard Kittel, "In 2 Th. 3:7,9 Paul offers himself as an example of earning his own bread and not being a burden to others. typos here is more than a pattern; it is an authoritative model. typos also occurs in Phil. which demands that the readers join in imitating Paul and also mark those who so walk. Here again Paul is not only a pattern but also an authoritative example. They are to walk as he does, but in so doing to obey. This element of obedience is very clear in I Cor. 4:16, for Paul has sent Timothy to remind the Corinthians of his "ways" in Christ, i.e., not merely his conduct but his directions. The same applies in 11:1. To be sure, Paul offers himself as a model in 10:32-33. He himself follows the same criterion that he enjoins on his readers. But imitation involves obeying the rule as well as copying Paul's example. This is why Paul adds: 'As I am of Christ.' If he simply meant that Christ is a model for him, then he would surely have pointed the Corinthians themselves directly to Christ and explained in what sense Christ is a model. Christ is, of course, a model in this sense in Rom. 15:1ff. and Phil. 2:4ff. But in these passages Paul develops the thought, and in any case it is not certain that Christ as model is really the central concept in Phil. 2:4ff. The point, then, is rather that the Corinthians should imitate Paul by heeding his word as he imitates Christ by understanding the apostolic ministry as Christ wishes. Paul's own authority rests on the superior authority of Christ The NT as a whole does not teach imitation in the primary sense of imitating an example but rather in the predominant sense of discipleship, i.e., of obedience to the word and will of the Lord either directly or by way of the apostles." Gerhard Kittel and Gerhard Friedrich, Theological Dictionary of the New Testament, abridged in one volume by Geoffrey W. Bromiley, (Grand Rapids: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1985), pp. 595, 596.

And his gifts were that some should be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, some pastors and teachers, to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ (Ephesians 4:11-13).

My relationship to a true man of God has been fundamental to the success and establishment of a church that has been described by Dr. Elton Trueblood and Dr. James Newby as "one of the most vital, exciting fellowships that we know of in the nation."

The desire to know a true man of God, one that follows the voice of God consistently, was conceived and nurtured early in my life, conceived by the teachings of Christianity and nurtured by parents who really believed the Bible. I found myself looking constantly for a person who lived as close to God as the outstanding saints in both the Old and New Testaments. The single burning desire of my heart was to find one who walked with God as did the ancients.

My desire became a dream and that dream was kept alive in high school by the writings of Catherine Marshall about her husband Peter. Her first two books, A Man Called Peter and Mr. Jones, Meet the Master, inspired me the most, the first because it confirmed that the voice of God could actually be heard in our time³ and the second because it contained a sermon entitled "Research Unlimited" which issued a challenge for spiritual research that would match that of the world of science.⁴

³ Catherine Marshall, A Man Called Peter, (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1951).

⁴ Peter Marshall, "Research Unlimited," Mr. Jones, Meet the Master, ed. Catherine Marshall (Westwood, New Jersey: Fleming H. Revell Company, 1949, 1950), pp. 63-74.

In college the two books which inspired my dream the most, other than the spiritual classics, were Rees Howells, Intercessor, written by Norman Grubb and The Company of the Committed, authored by one who was to become my teacher and encourager, Elton Trueblood.

One of the most significant events which I believe led me to a man who walks with God took place in 1960 on the banks of the Mississippi River. I was living with my parents and working for one of the cotton firms in downtown Memphis, Tennessee. Often, during the noon hour, I would walk and pray along the banks of that great river. One spring day I found myself praying aloud the desire of my heart, "Oh, Lord, if there is anyone who walks with You as did the men of the Old and New Testaments, I want to meet him before I die." The reading of Rees Howells, Intercessor the previous year had caused this deep longing to surface again.

It would take six years for that prayer to be answered. I had gone back to Anderson College in Anderson, Indiana, and my father was pastor of a church in Willshire, Ohio. One day in the spring of 1965, the phone rang and I heard Dad say excitedly, "Son, get up here as soon as you can! I want you to meet our evangelist, Robert Morgan." I packed hurriedly and made my journey to Willshire as quickly as possible. I was not disappointed. Robert and his wife Dorothy were so thoroughly and joyfully different from other Christians whom we knew that a close fellowship soon developed between them and my parents. One day while washing dishes together, my mother asked Dorothy if she was acquainted with the book Rees Howells, Intercessor. It was not long before Dorothy was at the foot of the stairs calling up to her husband, "Bob, come down quickly. These folks believe as we do." The substance

of that belief was that the working of God as described in the book of Acts is still possible today. As Peter Marshall said in the book, Mr. Jones, Meet the Master, and specifically in his sermon, "Research Unlimited":

God has not withdrawn any power that was available in the days of the first disciples. There is certainly no indication in the Bible that the power given to them was for a certain period only. . . .⁵

After the evening service that first night, while we were sitting around the table reviewing the presence of the Lord, I asked the question that I had asked several times before and to which I had always received a negative answer: "Do you know of anyone in the world who walks with God today as did the men of the Old and New Testaments?"

To my surprise Robert answered, "Yes, we do. We know someone like that. His name," he said, "is Loran Helm." They had known him since 1950.

I responded excitedly, "When may I meet him? I want to meet him as soon as possible!"

Robert's answer was one of wisdom and gentleness. "Oliver," he said, "you will meet him in God's time."

That meeting took place in April of 1966 and, without question, became the turning point in my life. Here was a man who walked with God moment by moment, a person to whom God spoke as He did to Abraham and Paul. The genuineness of his walk with God was proven shortly after we met. In June of that same year, Robert Morgan was the afternoon speaker at the annual conference of our denomination. Because of their longtime

⁵Marshall, op. cit., p. 71.

friendship, Loran Helm came to hear him speak. After the service, as we stood together reviewing the things of God, I was thinking of my wife Barbara. She had gone home to visit her parents in the south and had never met Loran Helm. As a minister's daughter she had been disappointed with most religious people and did not want to be a pastor's wife. She had told me repeatedly that I may have been called to be a pastor, but that she was not called to be a pastor's wife. This created a dilemma for me and that dilemma caused me to ask Loran, "What am I going to do? My wife does not profess to be a Christian and I am called to be a pastor." He started to tell me that it might be a long while before she would respond favorably, but the Holy Spirit checked him. He bowed his head and prayed. When he looked up he said that she would be saved soon (the Lord revealed to him that it would be in five weeks), but that I was not to say anything about this revelation. I was simply to love her and pray.

On the third day of the fifth week, as I was returning home from work, Barbara met me at the front door of our house with her Bible opened. She smiled and said, "I have given my heart to Jesus today and already have witnessed to two people about it." Three days later I shared with her the revelation given to Loran five weeks previously.

The proof of a Prophet as given in the Old Testament is that his predictions come true. In the New Testament the fruit of the Spirit is stressed. The final proof is the witness of the Holy Spirit, but unless one is hearing the voice of God, the first two may be the only criteria that can be employed. In the twenty years that I have known Loran Helm, the Lord has been so gracious to give him knowledge of His will over and over again, and it has been a wonderful privilege to see

confirmation through the years. The Old Testament criterion has been satisfied; however, the New Testament criterion of the fruit of the Spirit is equally important. Two significant observations will illustrate the outstanding integrity of this follower of Jesus.

The first observation concerns an event that took place just two weeks prior to the revelation of my wife's life change. Loran was preaching several nights at a small church in Muncie, Indiana. I was attending with great expectancy. One night he began to read out of a book a list of sins that hold back revival from the Church. These points came from a sermon preached by the great evangelist Charles G. Finney. When he reached the point referring to criticism (the King James calls this "evil speaking," which has primarily to do with sharing something negative about a third party not represented), he closed the book and looked at his wife and asked for a confirmation that was nothing short of incredible. He asked her to confirm that, by the grace of God, he had not criticized anyone since 1942, not even in the privacy of their home. Mrs. Helm stood and in a very bright and wonderful way witnessed that indeed her husband Loran had not at any time since been critical of anyone. He had not been critical of individuals, churches, denominations, nor their leadership. My church background was "holiness," but I did not even know, nor had I ever heard anyone point out, that the absence of criticism, coupled with a love for everyone, was central to an experience of holiness.

In his book A Voice in the Wilderness Loran relates, in a chapter entitled "Baptized with the Holy Spirit," this experience of the slaying of the self-life for days, weeks and months until he was baptized with wave after wave of divine love: an overwhelming love from

the Father for all men everywhere.⁶ Since that time, God has not permitted a critical word about anyone to be spoken by him. The Lord revealed to him that He could not use him in the Kingdom if he were critical, for criticism involves a judgment that belongs only to God.

The second illustration has to do with the Socratic model. (The Socratic model is far more important in the discovery of truth than the Socratic method.) When Socrates said "know thyself," he meant something quite different from what is sometimes conveyed. The oracle of God which was given to Socrates was that God found him to be the wisest man on the face of the earth. At first Socrates could not accept this. He had always found God to be right, but surely the Almighty was wrong this time. In a sense, Socrates' lifelong mission was to prove God wrong. He would seek out those who had reputations of wisdom only to find that the acclaim was unfounded. All of the reported wise men thought themselves to be wise. Socrates had at least learned the first lesson of wisdom, that God only is wise and that the wisdom of the wisest man is foolishness before Him. Thus, we have the famous dictum "know thyself" which means "know thine own ignorance." Socrates gave up everything to the fulfillment of his sacred task of teaching all men the true wisdom as it had been revealed to him. At the end of his life, while on trial before the men of Athens, he had to confess that the oracle of God was true because his lifetime search had resulted in finding only himself with the knowledge of his nothingness.

One day some years ago, the realization came to me that Loran

⁶Loran W. Helm, A Voice in the Wilderness, (Parker, Indiana: Evangel Voice Publications, 1973), pp. 183-191.

Helm was one of the men for whom Socrates was looking. I am convinced that few men in all of history have known themselves to be nothing. At one time Solomon had the revelation of his nothingness. It is revealed in his prayer of I Kings 3:7,9:

And now, O Lord my God, thou hast made thy servant king in place of David my father, although I am but a little child; I do not know how to go out or come in. Give thy servant therefore an understanding mind to govern thy people, that I may discern between good and evil; for who is able to govern this thy great people?

Unfortunately, Solomon lost the revelation.

The Apostle Paul had the revelation of his nothingness and never lost it. He wrote to those at Galatia: "For if any one thinks he is something, when he is nothing, he deceives himself" (Galatians 6:3).

A man who will make his own plans and strategies without consideration of God's will is a man who thinks himself to be something. The Prophet Jeremiah explains why in his prayer recorded in Jeremiah 10:23: "I know, O Lord, that the way of man is not in himself, that it is not in man who walks to direct his steps." When a person realizes this, he will want to wait upon God until God reveals His will. Few men have ever been willing to wait until God reveals what He wants. When Loran Helm left everything to go with God, although he was called immediately into evangelism, he refused to accept a preaching assignment until the Lord revealed that He was leading in that assignment. Consequently, he held only two or three meetings in his first two years. To go out on his own without the leading of the Holy Spirit would have been just that, a meeting held by himself. "Unless the Lord builds the house, those who build it labor in vain" (Psalm 127:1a).

After my wife's transformation, she began to ask me daily if I

were praying about going into the pastorate. She, who had been so unwilling to be a pastor's wife, had changed altogether. I thought it would be foolish to leave seminary while on a scholarship. However, after several days of being questioned by her, I sought the advice of the man of God. He thought it wisdom for me to stay in seminary, but when he prayed, the Lord disagreed with him. I remember his look of surprise after prayer was made as he said to me, "Oliver, you won't be going to school at all this fall."

Barbara spoke up excitedly, "That is what the Lord has been saying to me!"

I resigned my job, did not enter school in the fall, and after considering several invitations, I took a little church in Ohio because this was the leading of the Lord. It was not the most attractive offer, but it was God's will, and the Lord prospered our work there. My excitement was so great that I felt as if I had had an experience like Moses did at the burning bush. I remember how strangely the congregation looked at me when I told them that first Sunday morning, "As far as I am concerned, the center of the earth is right in this little village in Ohio." In just two and a half years, I was led by the Lord to resign on a Sunday morning when the attendance was at its highest. I can now see the reason we had to leave, even though the church was growing and we were about to build a new building. The people could not hear my cry to do only God's will. The Lord wanted me to have a hearing people, a people who would be willing to be on a mission without strategy--a strategy known only to God.

During the next few weeks, six new opportunities were presented to me. There were six churches where I could place my application. I

refused to apply anywhere until I knew the will of God. So I waited and I prayed. Finally, the board chairman informed me that I should consider leaving soon. Since I had resigned, they needed to install a new pastor as quickly as possible. I had made no application anywhere. I found myself in a precarious situation. Several minister friends wanted me to consider "this church" and "that church" because of a good salary or a good ministerial situation. I just wanted God's will. After five weeks of increasing pressure, I found myself praying on a Saturday morning, "Oh, God, tell Loran that I need him to pray with me about the church to which I should apply." I had called his home for prayer several days earlier when the pressure began to build, only to find that he was resting in Florida with his wife Florence and could not be reached. I prayed further, "Oh, Lord, You know where he is and You can do a better job than this telephone in contacting him. If it is Your will, have him call me."

My phone rang in two or three hours from the time that I prayed that prayer. He and his wife were resting in Hollywood, Florida, and there was no telephone in the room where they were staying. But after my prayer, the Lord began to speak to him of the need to call me. Now, here he was, on the telephone just as I had prayed. I explained to him that I had resigned about five weeks previously and had been given the names of six churches during the interlude but could not determine as yet which one of those, if any, God wanted me to serve as pastor. Loran said that he did not know either. I asked him if the Lord would let him pray over the list of six churches. Suddenly he said, "Read the names of each one to me!"

I read the names of each church slowly and on each of the first

five there was no answer; but when I named Scott Depot, West Virginia, I heard him say, "Hallelujah! God wants you at Scott Depot, West Virginia."

Chapter 2

A Window Into Reality

I feel as though all my life I have been looking for an alternative scene.

---Malcolm Muggeridge

My intense desire to find at least one man who walks with God like those of the Bible could not have been explained earlier in my life, but subsequent reflection has caused me to understand the reason for that search. Godly parents, evangelical worship services and Biblical training had contributed to a hunger that is universal to man---a desire to know reality.

William Barclay, in the introduction to his commentary of John's Gospel, points out that the Fourth Gospel makes use of the Greek concept of two worlds. Plato and the Greeks held that this present world is but a shadowy copy of the perfect and unseen world. Plato posited that somewhere there was a perfect pattern of everything good and beautiful of which all earthly goodness and beauty are imperfect and inadequate copies. The great reality, the supreme idea and the pattern of all patterns is God. The great problem is how to get into this world of reality; how does man get out of the shadows into the real world of eternal truths? John writes that Jesus is the way. Jesus is reality come to earth. "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, full of grace and truth; we have beheld his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father" (John 1:14). The life of Jesus was a window opening to the

reality of God.

As the Disciples followed Jesus, He revealed to them what God was really like by doing the will of God. He explained that reality could be known by His Disciples also. He told them that "if any man's will is to do his will, he shall know . . ." (John 7:17).⁷ This is astonishing and encouraging. Jesus is saying that the Disciples or anyone can know reality if that person or persons will do the will of God. The one who does God's will becomes himself a window into reality. Here is the opportunity to follow Christ, to learn the specific will of God. The general will of God has already been recorded from Genesis to Revelation, but the specific will of God can only be revealed to someone who desires to do God's will continuously.

In considering prayerfully the pastorates to which I should go, I had discussed the six possibilities with several other men, but only one man could tell me what the voice of God was saying. Scott Depot was to become reality in my life because I had found a window, Loran Helm, through which I could look at God.

The New Testament Apostles were windows of reality, but for most of them, becoming windows of reality was a slow process of obedience and sanctification. Peter, although filled with the Holy Spirit on the day of Pentecost, could not conceive that God was no respecter of persons and that "in every nation any one who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him" (Acts 10:34,35). He received that revelation of

⁷In his exegesis of John 7:17, A. T. Robertson reports that this knowledge (ginosko) is experiential and comes from willingness to do God's will. "For those who love God it is also true that obedience to God's will brings richer knowledge of God." A. T. Robertson, Word Pictures in the New Testament, V (Grand Rapids: Baker Book House, 1932), p. 123.

truth more than ten years after Pentecost while at Simon's house in Joppa. Just after the revelation came, Cornelius sent for him to come to speak and to worship in his Gentile household. Yet when one compares the life of Paul with all of the Disciples, the gap between their perspectives is so wide that one is left almost breathless. Paul, more than any other Apostle, became a window of reality into the Kingdom of God. The change in his life was so revolutionary and decisive that no explanation short of the power and revelation of God will suffice as an answer for his superior knowledge of Christianity. Paul states it succinctly in his Galatian letter: "For I did not receive it from man, nor was I taught it, but it came through a revelation of Jesus Christ" (Galatians 1:12). This immense knowledge is further underscored by the fact that the great Apostle did not know Jesus Christ in the flesh as did the other Apostles.

It was never the intention of our Heavenly Father, however, that only Jesus and the Apostles be windows of reality. Paul writes to the church at Ephesus that the Apostles, Prophets, Evangelists, Pastors and Teachers were gifts of Christ to the Church for the perfecting of the saints "until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ" (Ephesians 4:13). The Church will be a window into reality when she is at one with the Son and the Father. When that happens, the world will know reality--what God is like and that Jesus is loved and sent by the Father. In John 17:20-23, the prayer of Jesus was for the oneness of the Apostles and all who would believe:

I do not pray for these only, but also for those who

believe in me through their word, that they may all be one; even as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be in us, so that the world may believe that thou hast sent me. The glory which thou hast given me I have given to them, that they may be one even as we are one, I in them and thou in me, that they may become perfectly one, so that the world may know that thou hast sent me and hast loved them even as thou hast loved me.

The purpose of the Church is oneness in order that the world will believe.⁸ If the Church will become one in Christ, the power of the Holy Spirit will come again as it did at Pentecost and convince the world of the reality of God and that He sent Jesus to reconcile God and man.

I was looking for one man who walked with God when I met Loran Helm, but he was looking for men who walked with God. I was in search of a man but this man was in search of men, because the instrument of God for reaching the world is not a man but a group of persons called the Church. That group of persons is to be the window of reality to reveal the love of God and the person of Jesus to all men.

The revelation that I was to go to Scott Depot was extremely important. Our Heavenly Father knows where each ministry will fit. He knows where each pastor belongs. Unfortunately, many seem to be as reluctant as Jonah to go. Worse than that, many pastors do not have even the direction that Jonah had. What could be more wonderful for a pastor and a congregation than to know that they are for each other--that they are called together to do God's will on earth with the

⁸ Paul defines oneness in I Corinthians 1:10: "I appeal to you, brethren, by the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that all of you agree and that there be no dissensions among you, but that you be united in the same mind and the same judgment." Additionally, he explains the way to oneness as following the example of Christ who "emptied himself" and who "became obedient unto death" (Philippians 2:5-8).

realistic hope that the Kingdom of God will come to earth. For when God finds any one church that will do His will altogether, that portion of the Lord's prayer will come true, which says: "Thy kingdom come, Thy will be done, On earth as it is in heaven" (Matthew 6:10).

The importance of being a window into reality has been confirmed many times through the years but perhaps never so deeply underscored as when I was trying to determine in the late seventies if the church should present the musical The Sound of Music. Our church pianist, who was the director, asked me to pray about the possibility of presenting this to the community-at-large in connection with the opening of our new church sanctuary. A Christian church ordinarily would not present Broadway musicals in the church sanctuary. However, during my college days, I had seen both the stage production and the film of The Sound of Music and remembered that it was an inspiring and wholesome story. One of the criteria for the appropriateness of a church presentation is that it contribute to heart purity and devotion to God; but the final consideration must be that the Holy Spirit is leading. During the winter before the rehearsals would have to begin in June, my wife and I were sitting in a restaurant in Fort Lauderdale, Florida, with Loran. I asked him if the Lord would be pleased with the church presenting this musical to the community. He made no reply that evening, nor did he mention my question on subsequent nights on which we were together. Finally, on the night before we were to return to West Virginia, I asked him again by wording my concern this way: "If the Lord is not going to confirm this leading to present The Sound of Music, I am going to cancel any plans for it before we even start."

Then came a startling reply. Loran said, "Oliver, I heard your

question the first night, but each time I would start to tell you not to present the musical, the Holy Spirit would check me. Now, you know that I am not for anything worldly, but somehow I believe that God will be with you in this presentation. He is going to help someone through it." Since he did not go to movies, he had no way of judging the wholesomeness of a Hollywood or Broadway production. However, he knew that most of their productions would be inappropriate for a church presentation. So, wisely, he was about to tell me no, but the Holy Spirit did not agree. God knew that it was wholesome and that with minor changes it would be an acceptable and uplifting performance. After receiving the gracious permission from the Rodgers and Hammerstein Library to omit ballroom dancing in one scene, the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship presented The Sound of Music.⁹ Loran came to all of the performances and found the central reason why the Holy Spirit would reveal that this musical should be presented. The true story involves Maria, a postulant who is sent away from the convent by Mother Abbess to be the governess of the children of Captain Georg Von Trapp, an officer in the Austrian Navy. Maria falls in love with the widowed captain and thinking that this is not proper for a prospective nun, she leaves the house unannounced and hurries back to the abbey.

Later, in a meeting between the two, Mother Abbess confronts Maria with the following question: "Tell me, Maria, what is the most important lesson you've learned here?"

Maria answers, "To find out what is the will of God and to do

⁹THE SOUND OF MUSIC text by Howard Lindsay and Russel Crouse. Excerpts from the story of THE SOUND OF MUSIC• 1960 Estate of Richard Rodgers, Estate of Oscar Hammerstein II, Howard Lindsay Trust, Trust u/w Russel Crouse and Anna Crouse.

it."

The whole beautiful story, based on a true life account, is a demonstration of the importance and resultant blessing of finding God's will and doing it. Here was, parabolically, the story of Scott Depot Christ Fellowship and Oliver Hogue. Here, in a musical production, was the center of Loran Helm's life and message. He was grateful and thrilled, and at each production he would pray for the cast as they performed, hoping that in some way God would speak to souls in the audience about the absolute necessity of finding God's will and then doing it. According to Jesus, the persons who do God's will are the only ones known by His Heavenly Father on the day of judgment:

Not every one who says to me, "Lord, Lord," shall enter the kingdom of heaven, but he who does the will of my Father who is in heaven. On that day many will say to me, "Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in your name, and cast out demons in your name, and do many mighty works in your name?" And then will I declare to them, "I never knew you; depart from me, you evildoers" (Matthew 7:21-23).

Loran Helm was a window into reality. He, for quite good reasons, would not have recommended that Scott Depot present a Broadway musical; but the Holy Spirit knows everything, and He knew that it was best that we present this one. Someone was going to be encouraged to find God's will and do it. Had Loran not been walking with God, had he not been able to receive the revelation of the will of God by the witness of the Holy Spirit, had his life not been a window into reality, this great blessing and encouraging presentation would have been put aside.

We had never heard of another church presenting this fine musical, but it was God's will that we do it. The stories of blessing and appreciation are still coming in after a number of years. Whatever

God is in has no end; therefore, the results are eternal. Two Catholic ladies, who own and operate a Christian bookstore, attended thinking that our youth choir was presenting a few numbers from The Sound of Music. Instead, they found a full-scale production with props more elaborate than anything they had ever seen on a professional stage. The opening scene, which depicts nuns singing in Latin, was so anointed and worshipful that the Catholic ladies had the feeling that the Bishop had come for a visit. Indeed, the Bishop of our souls was there creating oneness between Catholic and Protestant believers. Today, those ladies and their family members are a part of one of our sister fellowships. One of them has told me that had it not been for the love and openness shown to them through the church and the musical, they could never have become a part of this fellowship that knows no boundaries of church membership.

The lessons learned from The Sound of Music paved the way for the Teays Valley School for the Arts, a ministry of our church which has sponsored the Charleston Symphony, the Vienna Choir Boys, the Charleston String Quartet and numerous fine art and visual presentations in the sanctuary as well as displays in the art gallery. The visiting performers have been so lifted by the excellent acoustics in the sanctuary and the response of the congregation that requests to come and perform are too numerous to accommodate. All major productions are made a matter of prayer. If the Holy Spirit does not direct, then the invitation is not extended. Recently a world-renowned group of musicians from a foreign country requested a performance at Scott Depot, but we could not accept their offer because the Holy Spirit was not leading. The key to our continual blessing and success has been the

leadership of the Holy Spirit. What has taken place in this religious community of approximately four hundred persons is beyond our fondest hopes and brightest dreams.

One night in the spring of 1972, I was unable to sleep. I was burdened over the advice of a fellow minister. He had informed me that I would be failing if I did not start a day care facility for small children. I could see the value of the service to working parents, but I knew that we could not fill that need unless the Holy Spirit were leading.

Whether day care or school, symphony or speaker, unless God is in the activities, a church will be found guilty of doing her own will instead of His will. The Holy Spirit must lead in each adventure of service and worship. We must not start a bus ministry, a Christmas program, a visitation team, or any other activity unless we have received specific orders from the Holy Spirit. Without God's blessing even a cottage prayer meeting can become a breeding ground for hostile and critical spirits. We must wait for His specific leading to engage in even traditional and good religious activities.

The hours rolled by and I kept praying over the advice given me until early in the morning. I had almost fallen asleep when the telephone rang. When I answered I heard the voice of my beloved friend, Loran. In those days, as now, his calls would come just at the time I most needed help. I explained the advice given me by the fellow minister and that I had been burdened for the last several hours because I did not want to start a day care program unless the Lord were really leading. He agreed and confirmed my thoughts about all of the unnecessary involvement intrinsic to such a program; but when he prayed,

I heard his voice change when he spoke these words, "Well, son, the Holy Spirit says it will work at Scott Depot. He wants you to have a day care program." Through the years there have been many difficulties, especially with the changing state regulations, but more than one thousand children have received the benefit of a day care facility that has been reported to be one of the finest in the state. The love and care of the outstanding Christian teachers is worth the children attending, but this program offers first-rate educational opportunities as well. However, the families which have come into our church family through the program have been the greater blessing. They are among the finest in the world. Somehow they were able to perceive that an excellent day care program with the best directors and teachers just did not happen. They came to services to observe for themselves a community of believers who were striving to obey God, both individually and collectively. These families have become some of the most enthusiastic supporters and participants in a mission that has no strategy except that which is revealed by the Holy Spirit.

At the same time that The Sound of Music opened in our new sanctuary, the Lord revealed that the church should begin a Christian school. It was growing more obvious that our public school systems nationwide were becoming increasingly secular and that our traditional Judeo-Christian values were being eroded and sometimes deliberately dismantled. A mechanistic philosophy rather than a spiritual one was being transmitted to our children. Of course, a pluralistic society influences such a philosophy, but the spiritual fallout to the children is permissivism and relativism. The result is the abandonment of self-control and the lack of respect for other people. To transmit

these basic religious values (to love God with all of one's heart and one's neighbor as oneself) now requires an alternate system of education. Yet even when the need seems to be obvious, the fundamental factor is the leading of the Holy Spirit. God knows the depth of the need and the time when such a school system should begin. God's will and wisdom is the true measure of our choices and the reality for which we seek. We waited His time. We can be sure the results will be beneficial to those who avail themselves of the opportunity to educate their children with the basic belief that man is created by God, is made in His image and therefore is accountable to Him. The worth of any person is derived from the reality that man is created in the image of God and is not the product of chaotic cosmic forces. A mechanistic view of life is an opaque window as far as reality is concerned. Again, the important questions are "what does God want and what is His timing for such a program?" The obstacles are so high and the difficulties are so numerous that any church must have the leading and power of God to begin and to continue.

Because of the present size of our facilities, we are limited to two hundred forty school children. We have a waiting list of hopeful children whose parents want them enrolled in our institution which has received the highest accreditation ratings. New property has been purchased and a new school building has been designed. Only the necessary finance and the leading of the Holy Spirit as to time of building remain. As of this writing, we have graduated our third senior class. Only God knows how valuable the school has been. Our church has been careful to describe our school programs as alternatives to our public schools. We have not been divisive or combative. Our own public

school system and the personnel involved are excellent; nevertheless, they are increasingly limited in providing education that addresses the spiritual nature and needs of man.

The key which determines whether we shall be a window into reality for all who would look through is that we do God's will. When we do, then the Kingdom of God comes on earth. That which we teach will have balance and perspective because it is real and abiding.

Although there are a number of windows into reality, one of the most important in the life of any church is the worship service. The New Testament says very little about the worship of the Early Church. The Corinthian letter contains passages of correction addressed to the abuse of the gifts of the Spirit, and these passages reveal what should not take place in a true worship service. But the letter to the Colossians recommends a simple procedure and gives the key to worship. Paul writes:

Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teach and admonish one another in all wisdom, and sing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs with thankfulness in your hearts to God (Colossians 3:16).

It is the next verse which gives us the key to worship: "And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God and the Father through Him" (Colossians 3:17). The renowned Greek scholar and commentator Dr. Richard C. H. Lenski explains in his commentary on Colossians¹⁰ that "to do 'all things in the name of the Lord Jesus' means 'in connection with the revelation of the Lord Jesus.'" He explains that the Greek word for name means a "revelation

¹⁰R. C. H. Lenski, The Interpretation of St. Paul's Epistles, (Minneapolis: Augsburg Publishing House, 1961), p. 179.

by which the Lord makes Himself known to us." Although the passage is instructive as to all of life, it follows the specific passage on worship and therefore reveals how worship should take place--at the revelation of the Lord Jesus Christ.

The background for letting the Holy Spirit plan the services came out of an experience Loran Helm had when he attended a Christian Ashram with Mary Webster and the late E. Stanley Jones in August of 1966 at Salina, Kansas. Dr. Jones had conceived the idea of the Christian Ashram from the Ashram movement in India. The program was conveniently divided into time units which were to be used as previously determined. Sometimes there would be an hour of silence, an hour of spiritual quest, an hour of sharing, or an hour of some other mode of worship. Mary noticed that Loran was severely restricted with the format and wrote of him:

. . . . I watched this beautifully "free spirit" nearly breaking his wings trying to fly inside a cocoon of the framework, boundaries, and constraints of a structural organization. It led me to suggest to him that it might prove more redemptive for him and others if he dropped the "cocoon", which bound him like a straight-jacket, and soared the heights with Jesus, free to do His bidding.¹¹

When Mary suggested that he find a place and wait upon God with a group of people for the program, Loran responded that the task was too big for him and wondered if, perhaps, Mary would consider doing it herself. Mary said, "No, Brother Loran, God has made it perfectly clear that you are the one."

The Holy Spirit confirmed those words of Mary, and in November of 1966, Loran and a group of Christians, including my wife and me,

¹¹Mary Webster, Foreword, A Voice In The Wilderness, by Loran W. Helm, (Parker, Indiana: Evangel Voice Publications, 1973), p. 9.

waited on God for three whole days with no program at all except as the Holy Spirit led. In each of the morning, noon and night services, the Lord would reveal what He wanted and in what order. There is no worship experience quite like the one in which the Holy Spirit is leading and giving the entire program. The Lord would reveal by the witness of the Holy Spirit who was to preach, sing, or testify and when each event was to take place. My first experience of waiting upon God was so moving that I wept for most of the three days. Even the meals were blessed with the presence of God.

In such manner began services that could be led entirely by the Holy Spirit. This, of course, would not have been strange to the Quakers three hundred years ago, nor to the Early Church, nor to anyone else who had received the revelation that God has a plan for every worship service. It is a must that we find that plan. It is not something that a group can rush into or press other people about, but it is something that God wants to do with the entire Church in order that we might experience true worship. Only the Holy Spirit can meet that need, for He alone is all-knowing and can give services that will help each submitted individual and each waiting congregation.

From that time on, Loran has let God do the worship planning and has challenged those who would listen to his teaching that we must wait upon God for the pattern and plan of each service. Such has been the aim of the Scott Depot congregation. We have been slow and careful in our progress from year to year, but by God's grace, our services have been alive with God's presence and power.

Before I came to Scott Depot, I began trying to determine what the Holy Spirit would have me preach. I remember calling Loran out of

frustration one day and saying, "I am unable to determine what God would have me preach. Why should I even try if I do not know with assurance what the Holy Spirit is saying."

He spoke reassuringly, "Oliver, I did not always know myself when I first started in the ministry. Just trust and pray. God will lead you more and more."

The person wanting to be led of God must first of all just trust God and be willing to be taught of God. The Lord indeed will take that willingness and teach one little by little. In over sixteen years at Scott Depot, the Holy Spirit has never let us down. He will never fail the trusting heart. Step by step, He will teach and guide until He has full control. The way the Lord leads, however, will probably be different where any congregation endeavors to trust Him.

For years now, the Holy Spirit has led for the music committee of the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship to meet an hour before service and pray concerning the musical selections. They pray for guidance about the prelude, the offertory, the hymns, the congregational numbers and the special singing. When I arrive at church just before the service, I am handed the list of songs for which the Holy Spirit has directed, and I pray for guidance to know when to use them in the worship service. The music committee is composed of two pastors, the music director and two people who do not know music at all but who have the inner voice of God. They need not know music, just what music the Holy Spirit is selecting. In fact, there seems to be some wisdom in choosing two congregational persons who do not know music. The confirming witness from them gives courage to those members who know music but might wonder how odd a particular selection may be. It is impossible to know how the

Holy Spirit will work in any given worship service; therefore, He is the only one who knows what is needed.

At one point a few years ago, the Lord revealed that I was to preach through the book of Romans. This, of course, simplified the sermon selections. Sunday mornings I preached from the Roman letter. Sunday evenings and Wednesdays were given to elaborating on the theme set by the sermon Sunday mornings or perhaps on related topics.

Each service is an adventure and a challenge. The congregation looks forward to what will be sung and preached because they know that the Lord is leading, not the minister. Years of following the Lord in the worship services have confirmed to the people that God really is leading. Some know by the confirming witness in their hearts. Others know because God speaks to them about a personal need or concern that has been held hidden within the heart.

Once in a while the Lord will lead for a hymn or a spiritual song that the congregation does not know and has never practiced. This does not disturb the people because they sense the need of the message contained in that particular song. There have been times when a visitor has come to one of us after a service wanting to know why we chose a number which was such a blessing to him. Sometimes that explains why an unknown song was chosen. The Lord does not leave visitors out when He is leading nor anyone else He wishes to touch with His grace and love.

Of course, this means that the sanctuary and the youth choirs, as well as the special singers, have a rather large repertoire at all times; but this only makes for richer and fuller services as the Holy Spirit has a wide range from which to choose. The sanctuary choir and

our church soloist are each ready to sing over a hundred numbers without a rehearsal.

It would be hard to convey the level of positive expectation that builds up in the congregation. How helpful it is to know that when the Lord is leading, there is food for the soul. Oh, how satisfying that food is! Even the liturgy and responsive readings take on new life because the Lord has chosen them. The confirmation that God has led is in the satisfaction He brings to the waiting worshipper.

This kind of worship service which is charged with substance and vitality is a window into reality. It serves real needs because God knows what they are. The key is this--finding the will of God for any worship service. Doing God's will brings the Kingdom of God to earth and results in the renewal of the worshipping body.

A window into reality can be a person, a day care ministry, a Christian school, or a worshipping body of believers. The criterion is simply this--the will of God.

Chapter 3

The Unfolding Mission

They went not forth, or preached in their own time or will, but in the will of God.

---William Penn

For a person or a fellowship of believers to have genuine spiritual vitality there must be a vital connection to the living God by a mission of continual obedience to His general and specific will. He may never reveal until Heaven all that would result if believers would simply obey Him. The important thing is that we must obey. Many, if not most, of the deep purposes of God are not revealed to us. We should love Him enough to obey and leave the results to Him.

The revelation that my ministry would triple took place on the second trip to the Holy Land. That was not the final trip. Indeed many trips were to follow as a result of the witness of the Holy Spirit. The Lord has sent us abroad twenty-six times to thirty foreign countries. Twenty of those trips have been to Israel. We went with no other motive but to obey God. Nevertheless, the fact that the Lord witnessed repeatedly caused me to pay special attention and to be alerted for a unique and further understanding of His will.

The mission is always an unfolding one. The particular goals and strategy are the Lord's to prescribe. The origin of the word strategy reveals why. Strategy, strategic, and stratagem come from the Greek stratos (army), plus agein (to lead), to lead an army, to be a

general; hence a strategy is a piece of generalship. To have a strategy is to be the general; and in the Christian army only Jesus Christ, through the leadership of the Holy Spirit, can be the General. Our only mission from our viewpoint can be to follow the General as He sets the strategy.

Pope John Paul I, in his little known but excellent book entitled Illustrissimi, illustrates the kind of mission Christians should have by writing an open letter to Saint Francis de Sales, a saint of the Catholic Church, who is best known in wider Christian circles for his book, Introduction to the Devout Life and Treatise on Divine Love.

According to you, the man who loves God must board the ship of God, determined to accept the course set by His commandments, by the guidance of those who represent Him, and by the situations and circumstances of life that He permits.

You imagined an interview with Marguerite, when she was about to embark for the Orient with her husband, Saint Louis IX, king of France:

"Where are you going, Madame?"

"Where the king goes."

"But do you know exactly where the king is going?"

"He has told me in a general way. I am not concerned to know where he is going, however: I care only about going with him."

"Then, Madame, you have no idea of this voyage?"

"None save the idea of being in the company of my dear lord and husband."

"Your husband will go to Egypt, he will stop at Damietta, at Acre, and in several other places; do you not wish, Madame, to go there also?"

"No, in truth. I think only of being near my king; the places where he goes have no importance at all for me, except for the fact that he will be there. I am not so much traveling with him as following him. I do not care about the voyage, but am content with the presence of the king."

That king is God, and we are all Marguerites if we love God really.¹²

¹² Albino Luciani, Illustrissimi, (Boston/Toronto: Little, Brown and Company, 1978), pp. 105, 106.

The important thing in mission is that we follow. But we must love Him as Marguerite did Saint Louis IX if we are to complete our mission. It is impossible to have a strategy of mission because He alone has the plans and seldom reveals His intentions very far ahead. God will fulfill His mission through us if we leave the strategy to Him. In fact if we do our own figuring, we will only succeed in blocking His plan and aborting our own mission. In Mark, the earliest gospel, the very first recorded words spoken directly to His Disciples were "follow me" (Mark 1:17). He spoke those words to Simon and Andrew as they were casting their net into the sea. Amazingly, they were also the last spoken words recorded in the last Gospel. Jesus had just revealed what kind of death Peter would die and that he would live to be an old man before it took place. Peter then inquired about the Apostle John and asked, "'Lord, what about this man?' Jesus said to him, 'If it is my will that he remain until I come, what is that to you? Follow me!'" (John 21:21-22). So the first words spoken to His Disciples as recorded by Mark and the last words spoken to His Disciples as recorded by John are "follow me." The mission is to declare and to demonstrate the reign of God. The how of that mission, the strategy of following, is left to God.

In taking trips abroad repeatedly, we began to see that places and sights were not primary, but people. God wanted us to be a witness in love. And since the Holy Spirit witnessed so many times about going to Israel, we could see increasingly that we had a responsibility to the sons of Abraham. We were to love them for their sakes and for the sake of our indebtedness to them.

At first the Jewish travel people in Israel were courteous but

reserved. We discovered the reason some years later when they explained that Christian people had tried to convert them so often through the years that they had hardened to the possibility of Christianity being valid. Their contemporary impression coupled with historical events such as the Crusades, the Inquisition and the Holocaust made it impossible to give Christians any credibility whatsoever.

Eugene B. Borowitz records the Jewish attitude in his book, Liberal Judaism, "We might be more inclined to give Christian claims some credence had we seen Christians through the ages behave as models of a redeemed humanity."¹³ Earlier in that same book, he illustrates his point with the chasidic rebbe of Vitebsk, Menahem Mendel, who immigrated to Jerusalem in the eighteenth century.

One day a man went up to the Mount of Olives and began blowing a shofar. People thought the Messiah had arrived and someone came running to Menahem Mendel with the good news. He went to the window and saw the Jerusalemites going about their business in the usual way. He said simply, "The Messiah hasn't come," and returned to his study and prayer.¹⁴

Borowitz then advises the Jewish people:

Should someone tell you that the Messiah has appeared, may I urge you not to start studying the relevant biblical texts, as valuable as that might be; instead go to the window and see what is going on in the world. You should quickly be able to see whether the Jewish hopes for our people and for all humanity have been fulfilled.¹⁵

If we Christians are redeemed and are infused with the power of God, then we are going to have to be models of a redeemed humanity before anyone can give credence to our claims. However, not only with

¹³Eugene B. Borowitz, Liberal Judaism, (New York: Union of American Hebrew Congregations, 1984), p. 78.

¹⁴Ibid., p. 77.

¹⁵Ibid., p. 78.

the Jewish people, but with any people, we are going to have to love without any hidden motive before there can be any credibility. Jesus made it clear in the Sermon on the Mount that we were to love all men, even our enemies (and the Jewish people are our friends), with the same love as our Father in Heaven who makes His sun to rise on the evil and the good and sends rain on the just and on the unjust. He summarized that point by commanding: "You, therefore, must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect" (Matthew 5:48).

We discovered in our repeated travels that we were called upon as God's children simply to love people everywhere without condition and without respect of persons. One day our travel agent observed, "Reverend Helm and his people do not go primarily to see the sights but to love the people." When the Jewish people realized that we were not a proselyting group but came only to love them, they began to bring their children to our meetings. The joy of the Lord and the love of God made these meetings a wonderful place to be. We have watched the children grow up, marry and start families of their own. In the spring of 1982, Loran and Florence, my wife and I, and two of our travel agents surprised our head guide and his wife by traveling to Israel to attend the wedding of their daughter.

A tremendous thing took place in the synagogue in Tel Aviv, Israel. During the wedding ceremony, Joseph Mizrachi, the manager and owner of the Israeli touring company that hosts us in Israel, took Loran's hand and mine and said to his business partner, "Reverend Hogue and Reverend Helm are my best friends on the earth." Later, he repeated those same words at the wedding reception.

While visiting in our head guide's home, his mother-in-law,

after meeting us for the first time, smiled graciously and took her seat without speaking to us because she could not speak English. She was an elderly woman who, by the grace of God, had escaped the horrors of the Holocaust while many in her family had not. She was in the room perhaps thirty minutes to an hour when it came time for us to leave. Just before we departed she began speaking excitedly in Hebrew and would not be hushed. Finally, her request was translated to us. She wanted Loran to pray a prayer for the desire of her heart. Back home when I shared this with one of our local rabbis, he informed me of the uniqueness of the incident. In fact he declared that no Hebrew mother would ask even the Pope to pray for her about anything. This mother had felt the love of God, knew that our party and leader were of God and therefore requested prayer.

Through the years, the number of such beautiful stories has grown. On our fifth journey our driver's name was Samuel. One day while on tour, he requested that our group sing for him "Silent Night, Holy Night." I was a bit shocked that a Jewish bus driver would request a Christian group to sing a song of the virgin birth of Jesus. Nevertheless, I turned to my people and shared with them the sincere request. As they were singing, the glory of the Lord filled the bus, and I observed that tears were running down Samuel's face. I said nothing then, but several days later, just before we boarded the plane to return home, Samuel turned to us and said, "Do you remember when I requested that you sing 'Silent Night, Holy Night'?" I responded in the affirmative. He went on to explain that he had served in the British Army during World War II, and just before midnight one Christmas Eve, the Christian British soldiers began to sing the much-loved carol.

Samuel said that through the years he had longed to request it of some Christian group and felt that our people were the right ones to ask. He was blessed again as he had been during the war.

To our delight and surprise, Samuel was assigned to our bus on our next trip. As I stepped on the bus and took my place on the front seat, I heard him speak to our new guide, Michael. His words have astonished me until this very day. He said to Michael, "You see this pastor and his people here?" Michael smiled and acknowledged that he saw us. "Well," said Samuel, "when they came last year to Israel, they touched my life so much that I began to attend the synagogue again after an absence of twenty-five years. My wife thinks I'm crazy--the synagogue is just right across from our house." Our love for Samuel had opened the way for him to request the desire of his heart. He was touched so deeply by our love and the anointing of the Spirit upon the singing that the desire to worship God had surfaced again. He had returned to the synagogue to renew his search for God. The Lord had chosen us as His witnesses through love and music to call Samuel back to faith in Him.

The rest is up to God and Samuel. Some, perhaps, would fault me for not telling him the story of Jesus, but Samuel already knew the story of Jesus. Most of the drivers are guides also. The best witness we could have made was through love and music. Only God can give revelation as to the way of salvation. Anything more than that, in this particular case, would have stopped the call of God on Samuel and made our motives suspect. We can speak a word five minutes or thirty years too soon and abort the work of the Holy Spirit. Indiscriminate witnessing and sharing of the plan of salvation is doing more damage

than good. When we try to do the work of God, we block the very thing we are trying to accomplish. Our mission is to reveal God and the importance of doing His will so that all men will submit themselves to the reign of God. But, if we do not follow Him and His strategy, we will abort our mission. Unconditional love is a safe strategy already enjoined upon us by Jesus Himself. Music is universally appreciated; therefore, it is safe to be witnesses with music in love in most all nations.

I remember a certain bus driver in Italy. At first we did not know that some time previous to our meeting him, he had been sued for the death of a number of fishermen who had been killed on his boat. The families of the deceased had satisfied their claims against him in Italian courts until he had nothing left. We did not know how much the love of God had touched him in our singing until we reached St. Mark's Square in Venice. Our driver offered money to the string ensemble that was already playing in the square if they would cease playing and let us sing. As we began to sing "Amazing Grace," a phenomenal thing happened. The anointing and love in our hearts expressed through the singing instantly touched a great number of people standing on those famous streets and in the shops. They came running to us until we were encircled. As we finished, the shouts of appreciation were heard all around us in different languages. We were asked to sing again and again. After our performance, people in the audience began to question us, and several helped us to interpret who we were and the purpose of our visit to their city. Our driver was proud and thrilled and our relationship with him deepened. How deeply he really felt was revealed when we boarded the plane at Milan for another country several days

later. Just before we boarded, the driver embraced every man and kissed the back of each lady's hand. As he pulled away from the air terminal, I saw him, like Samuel, wiping tears from his eyes. None of us could speak Italian; but we were the Body of Christ, and we were speaking a language that touches the heart.

In Vienna the tourist office assigned a guide to our bus who was inebriated. When we expressed our concern to the office personnel, we were told that their agency had heard of our tour group and thought that it would benefit this guide to be with us. They also told us that our guide had been abused by the Nazis during World War II and had never recovered. We reconsidered, of course, and were thankful that the travel personnel perceived our mission at that point better than we did. We were to love this guide as well as the bus driver, and love we did. The next day our guide, sober and bright, started the morning by stating, rather apologetically, that our sights for that day would not be all that interesting. Our spirits were not dampened, and we simply proceeded with our usual enthusiasm to our guide's astonishment. It proved to be one of our most enjoyable days, and as we parted with the guide at the end of the day, there were many hugs and handshakes. Our guide's face was shining and tears glistened in her eyes. We knew that our mission had been accomplished in Vienna.

One definite value resulting from international travel is a broadening view or perspective of nations, religions and cultures. Naturally, repeated visits to Israel would arouse an interest in Jewish people everywhere. Israel is unique in this respect, for nearly all Jewish people identify with Israel whether they live there or not. The restoration of Israel coupled with the horrors of the Holocaust have

unified the Jewish people more than any other factors in modern history. Hitler and the Nazis made no distinction between observant or non-observant Jews. They tried to eliminate anyone and everyone who had Jewish blood. The restoration of Jewish nationhood brought security to Jewish people everywhere, if for no other reason than refuge.

One may have a desire to know Jewish people as close personal friends; however, to have this desire realized is not easily accomplished. You just do not walk up to someone who is Jewish, or anyone else for that matter, and say, "I want to be your friend." The Lord knew that my desire was genuine and that I had committed that aspiration to Him. David, the Hebrew psalmist, wrote in Psalm 37:4,5: "Take delight in the Lord, and he will give you the desires of your heart. Commit your way to the Lord; trust in him, and he will act." I did exactly that.

One Sunday morning a beautiful young woman came to the platform at the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship after the morning message. As she spoke to me, I was reminded of the scriptural promise concerning the desire of the heart. She spoke with a bright smile and a note of excitement in her voice: "Pastor Hogue, I am a Jew. My previous experience in all other Christian churches has been that when I revealed my Jewishness I received negative responses. But this morning, when I shared with several people that I was a Jew, one would have thought that I was someone very important. Everyone with whom I shared responded positively and some said, 'Oh, how wonderful to be Jewish. We love the Jewish people and we love Israel.' Some told me that they have gone to Israel several times." She continued, "I am a friend and neighbor of one of your parishioners, and I started coming to this church five weeks

ago. I told her not to reveal to anyone that I was Jewish until I did so myself. Pastor, I do not understand about Jesus Christ, but I do know that after visiting this congregation and hearing you these last several weeks, that the love of the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob is in this place. May I come here and worship God?" She then threw her arms around my neck and gave me one of the most sincere, enthusiastic hugs that I have ever received from any person. Her neighbor and our parishioner, with whom she had been attending church, had experienced a total transformation in her own life two years previously. She had lived for God so faithfully that the young Jewish woman became eager to know what had brought about such a great change in her friend's life. One day she said to her Christian neighbor, "I can't stand it any longer. Take me to the source of your happiness."

Knowing that her friend was Jewish, our young parishioner asked, "Would you be willing to go to my church?"

Her Jewish friend exclaimed, "I'll go with you any place that produces happiness like this!"

One Sunday morning I related to my congregation my recent experience in attending the Yom Kippur service at the Jewish temple in Charleston. I was excited because I knew that the traditions extended back to and before the time of Jesus. I did not remember that our Jewish friend was in the audience. After the service was over she came up to me and, in that wonderful way of hers, she exclaimed, "Oh, pastor, that was my congregation you attended last night. I was there and did not know that you were in our service at all." Only then did I realize that she was an observant Jew. She attended our church for several weeks before she moved to another state. After she moved away, there

seemed to be an emptiness that could not be filled. Before leaving, she had shared with me about the way that God was working in her life. She was endeavoring to hear the voice of God and submit her life entirely to His commandments.

The promise of eternal life is the guarantee that the experience of loving people is not a cruel joke played upon us by life. Paul wrote to the Corinthians: "If for this life only we have hoped in Christ, we are of all men most to be pitied" (I Corinthians 15:19). If we were to experience a loving relationship with someone and have that relationship come to an end never to be renewed, life would be a tragedy. It is the promise of Heaven and of the eternal continuation of friendship and love that keeps severed relationships from becoming too painful to endure. The promise of an eternal relationship of love in the Kingdom of God--the possibility of knowing our young Jewish friend forever--motivates me and the Scott Depot congregation to continue to do God's will always. The rewards are eternally satisfying.

The beautiful love and fellowship with this young Jewish woman deepened our desire to know Jewish people in America, but for reasons stated previously, I knew only God could make it possible. In order to achieve so worthy a goal, the strategy must be left to the Holy Spirit.

One thing that I could do however was to learn all I could about the Jewish way of living. I purchased the Encyclopedia Judaica and The Babylonian Talmud, and I joined a Jewish book club. If God were to give us more Jewish friends like the one we had just found, it seemed important to know the sensitivities and thinking of the children of Abraham.

In the fall of 1981, I had been studying Jewish High Holy Days,

especially Rosh Hashanah, the New Year festival, and Yom Kippur, the Day of Atonement, which is the most solemn and important day in the Jewish year. I had read that sometimes an offering for the poor is taken by the Jewish people on the eve of Yom Kippur. That year our Wednesday night service fell on the eve of Yom Kippur. Because an understanding of the Day of Atonement was so vital in understanding the work of Christ, the Paschal Lamb, as the atonement for sins, I had prepared a lesson explaining the Hebrew origins. When the time came for the offering, I had a definite leading of the Holy Spirit to join the Jewish people in their offering for the poor. I shared the leading with the congregation and explained that I would take the offering on the next day, Yom Kippur, to the synagogue or temple and present it to the Jewish people to help the poor. (Little did I realize then how important that offering was to become. It became the open door to a relationship with Jewish people in America that has astonished nearly all who have learned about it.) The next morning I called Congregation B'Nai Israel and asked for an appointment with the rabbi. I was told to come between services sometime just after noon. One of the greatest moments of my life took place just after I walked into Rabbi Israel Koller's office that day. I introduced myself, explained my purpose for coming, and then presented him with a check from our church. It was a small amount of just over three hundred dollars, but one would have thought that the amount was three thousand dollars by the rabbi's response. When I saw the astonished look on his face, I quickly tried to explain the many trips to Israel which had resulted in the offering I was now presenting to him. He kept interrupting me, and I kept trying to explain the background. I did not want to appear presumptuous. Finally he said to

me, "Pastor Hogue, excuse me, but no Christian church has ever done this before. I am simply astonished and amazed." He paused and then stated forthrightly, "The next time you go to Israel, I want to go with you." His warmth and receptivity quickly dispelled whatever fears I may have had, and I extended an invitation for him to come and speak to our congregation. He accepted that invitation and asked if he could bring his class of confirmation students with him. Of course, I responded in the affirmative. That began an annual visit with the confirmation students and, occasionally, some of their parents also.

The Lord led for a small group of six people to travel to Israel the following spring. They attended the wedding of the daughter of our head guide in Tel Aviv: a story that has already been told in this chapter. It was almost two years until the Holy Spirit witnessed that a large group should return for a tour. The leading, however, was extremely important.

During the summer, almost two years after my friendship began with Rabbi Koller, the Holy Spirit led Loran Helm to conduct a series of services at Scott Depot. One night in one of those services just before the offering was to be taken, I was sharing with the rather large audience the story of the young Jewish woman who had visited our church and become our friend. While telling the story, I came to the place where she had revealed her Jewish identity and the response of love and joy given by our congregation upon finding out she was Jewish. During this time of sharing, the Holy Spirit spoke to Loran and revealed that we would be going to Israel again. The Holy Spirit revealed that we should leave on December 11. The next day our School for the Arts director was visiting in the home of two other Jewish friends whom we

had recently met, and while he was there, Rabbi Koller came by. Just as our arts director was about to leave, he happened to mention that we would be leaving for Israel on the following December 11. Rabbi Koller, at that moment, took a datebook from his pocket and asked one of his Jewish friends to read aloud what he had written in it in Hebrew. The friend read, "Trip to Tel Aviv - December 11." It seemed as if the air were suddenly filled with electricity. "Don't tell Pastor Hogue," said Rabbi Koller. "Let me tell him."

When he called me, he said, "This is not coincidence. What is happening between you and me is attacking my innate and inborn prejudices. How do you explain it?"

I responded, "Rabbi Koller, we serve a great God who has a much broader perspective of His Kingdom than you or I. We are His servants and He wants us together." That seemed to be an acceptable answer for him. It was beginning to be evident to him that the voice of God was leading.

We took the rabbi and three other Jewish friends with us on that December trip. The Charleston Daily Mail headlined the large, four-column article about our trip: "Christians, Jews Unite for Trip to Holy Land." The following excerpts from that article sum up the journey:

Local Christians and Jews together are making a pilgrimage to the Holy Land this month, and the Christians are hosts to the Jews but the Jews are hosts to the Christians.

If that's confusing, consider:

About a hundred members of the Christian church known as Scott Depot Christ Fellowship are taking four Jews with them when they visit the Holy Land.

One of the Jews is Rabbi Israel B. Koller of Temple Israel in Charleston. The others are Arie and Rachel Lipsky and their young son, Gilad.

The four will be guests of the Christians from Teays Valley - while at the same time they will be spiritual and

cultural hosts and advisers to the Christians in the country of Christ's heritage.¹⁶

Rabbi Koller joined me when I spoke to the staff of the Christian Embassy in Jerusalem. Johann Luckoff, International Director of the Embassy, had heard of our vital relationship with the Jewish people on both sides of the Atlantic and had invited me to speak to the Embassy staff. My presentation was made many times more effective when Rabbi Koller walked in with me. The essence of my presentation was that an effective relationship with the Jewish people can take place only by following the voice of God. If we are to love the Jewish people as God does and if that love is to be reciprocated, we as Christian people must love without hidden motives. Ours must be a mission without strategy.

In an interview with Rabbi Koller and me which was conducted for a Christian magazine, the young reporter asked pointedly how such a relationship could prevail given the historical and theological differences between Judaism and Christianity. The rabbi gave an answer that was revealing and helpful. He explained that what had frightened the Jewish people throughout history was not the missionary nature of Christianity. Judaism had once been missionary. What has frightened the Jewish people is the reaction of Christians when the offer of Christ is refused. History has shown repeatedly that the reaction has been one of persecution and hatred. The thing that made our relationship possible was that he sensed that I, Pastor Hogue, would still be there loving him even if the offer of Christ were refused.

¹⁶ Adrian Gwin, "Christians, Jews Unite for Trip to Holy Land," Charleston Daily Mail [Charleston, West Virginia], December 5, 1983, p. 6B, Columns 1-4.

Of course, he sensed rightly what my response would be. I am enjoined by Jesus, a Jew whom I believe to be the Christ, to love all men everywhere. My love must never be conditional regardless of what men do with my concept of truth. The mission is always one of love and the strategy of this mission must always be left to Christ Himself. If, indeed, Jesus Christ is the Son of God and I am a follower of His, my actions and my reactions must always be Christlike and Godlike.

In August of 1986, the Holy Spirit witnessed that we should journey again to the land of the Patriarchs, Prophets and Apostles. More than fifty members of our Scott Depot congregation would be taking this trip of obedience and mission to Israel. When I called my friend, Israel Koller, to tell him about this trip to Israel, he checked his calendar and discovered that August was the only available time that he had in which to make the journey with us. Several weeks previously he had written to me to say that he would be unable to go in 1986 due to a full schedule. However, a few days later, he wrote back saying that maybe he should reconsider since he had experienced a dream that he was in Israel taking money to several needy institutions. I had asked him to be, as before, our honorary host to the land of our faith and he consented.

In the meantime the Lipskys had moved to Buffalo, New York, in order that Arie could fill the position of principle cellist for the Buffalo Philharmonic. They invited me to speak to the people of that city on Israel Education Day, an event sponsored by the Jewish Federation of Greater Buffalo, on the topic "A Christian Views Israel." Since this was a new type of assignment, I called Rabbi Koller for a working lunch and asked him what would impress the Jewish people of

Buffalo. He later wrote the essence of his response in a letter for me to take with me for that lecture. An excerpt from that letter underscores the title of this chapter:

The association with Israel by the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship and the Revival for Our Day (RFOD) is based on more than the usual motivations which move Christians to make a pilgrimage to the Holy Land. Your many visits, twenty, I believe, are testimonies to the deep and abiding love which you and your congregants harbor for the People of Israel in particular and for the Jewish community in general.

I know that your visits to Israel are a great sacrifice for all your congregants. The economic base underlying the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship is anything but wide or munificent. Yet your congregants sacrifice and make do without many other things in order to save funds for a visit to Israel which is as inspiring to the Israelis as to those who go with you.¹⁷

With reference to Israel, in the beginning our mission of obedience was obviously to visit the holy sites, where persons and events had given birth to our faith, and thus to encourage a strong faith and a deeper interest in the Bible. That part of our mission has been and still is being accomplished when first time travelers go with us. But the greater goal, to love and comfort the people of Israel (Isaiah 40:1,2), became obvious and clear with successive journeys. The mission unfolded before us as we followed the voice of Jesus back to the country where He became flesh. He wanted us to comfort the children of Abraham, eventually, on both sides of the Atlantic. As Christians, we would be fulfilling the ancient mission given first to the Jews themselves. Dennis Prager, a Jewish social and political commentator, explains the mission of the Jews in his excellent paper "Ultimate Issues":

¹⁷Israel B. Koller, Letter to author, April 7, 1986, Used by permission.

Why be Jewish? Because the Jewish people has a religious/moral/holy mission to "repair the world under God's rule." Because the Jews are bidden by God to be a "light unto the nations." Because Judaism fills one's life with a holiness, meaning and joy that is not attainable to the uncommitted Jew. And because Judaism has distinctive values which if communicated to the world, will reduce human suffering, help to extinguish evil, and prevent holocausts (which are taking place with greater frequency and more apathy---see Afghanistan in this issue).¹⁸

If you remove the name Jewish and insert the name Christian, you can readily see some of the similarities of the Christian mission to that of the Jewish one.

This mission of love and obedience must encompass our choices and our relationships in every area of our lives. When it does, lives can be redeemed, a world can be changed and our God can be glorified.

By God's wonderful grace, the Lord has helped the fellowship of believers at the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship to be an oasis of love and hope in a desert of dry and disappointing church experiences and religious forms, a land of promise in a world of desperate people looking for hope, wholeness and life. Professed atheists have experienced the life-changing touch of God's redeeming love through the uncritical, childlike, joy-filled caring of a group of people whose own hearts have been touched by that same divine love. Homosexuals have found their lives rescued and transformed through the forgiveness and fellowship of a group of God-trusting people. Young people have found a cause and an adventure in the challenge of Christ's Kingdom. Ministers of other churches have been refreshed and encouraged by the Christlike caring of a community of committed Christians. The broken, the

¹⁸Dennis Prager, "The Greatest Jewish Problem," Ultimate Issues, Volume 1 Number 2, Spring 1985, p. 7.

persecuted, the outcasts of churchdom have found a home and healing. Other churches have been challenged and revived by a word or a visit from these loving people who are thrilled with the call of the Kingdom. All of this, not because of any thought-out strategy, but because of a mission simply to wait upon God, to be wholly His, and to know and do His will.

The mission is an unfolding one because God's purposes are deeper than our own. It is a mission without strategy because only the General, Jesus Christ, knows the plans. Only if this strategy is left to God can we realize our mission, for only He has the knowledge, the wisdom and the power to set the course and secure its completion. This we know: to go His way is to go the way of life. It is our unfolding mission.

Chapter 4

The Ensuing Struggle

We cannot be rightly prepared for the fierce struggle of our generation if we do not understand the intensity of the opposition to a committed Christianity.

---Elton Trueblood

One of the most important and confirming signs that any pastor is in the right place is the struggle that ensues after his arrival. If the pastor is a true servant of God and the assignment is revealed by the Holy Spirit, then there will be a strong and significant struggle in that congregation.

Since all of hell is against anyone reaching God's perfect will, the path to it is strewn with enormous difficulties and obstacles.

. . . whenever God sends a true servant to any congregation, that people will begin to experience unusual struggles and upheavals.¹⁹

This struggle must be understood and appreciated, or the mission will likely be aborted. All who are servants of God begin an assignment with integrity but often fail to recognize that the devil hates nothing more than consistent loyalty to the will of God. If that pastor continues to obey the voice of God in worship services, related ministries and general church polity, the enemy will oppose violently.

Specifically, one of the evidences that the right pastor is with the right people is division in the congregation. Any minister that

¹⁹ Helm, op. cit., p. 158.

cannot divide the average nominal congregation should not be able to keep his ordination certificate. I beg the patience and careful consideration of the reader at this point. It is very important that this statement not be misunderstood. There is a division that is not of God. Church splits that are caused by unloving, unwise, dictatorial leaders are not of God. A wolf will divide the flock and cause great harm, but the average congregation in contemporary Christianity will also divide when a true shepherd is sent by Christ Himself. Yet most church councils hold the opposite viewpoint. They believe that a pastor ought to keep any church group together and build on that foundation. One cannot build a church upon both those who have faith and those who do not. A pastor sent by the Holy Spirit will bring to the faithless a sword, not peace. Peace can come only when the majority of persons, especially in the leadership positions, are willing to do the will of God no matter what the cost. And the cost is everything. Usually a division accompanies the initiation of renewal.

Jesus explained that it was indeed His purpose to bring division: "I came to cast fire upon the earth Do you think that I have come to give peace on earth? No, I tell you, but rather division" (Luke 12:49a,51).

The Apostle John remembered that division did indeed come. Once during the Feast of Tabernacles, Jesus stood and cried loudly that if those who were thirsty would believe on Him, streams of living water would flow from within them. John records the result of those who heard this cry: "So there was a division among the people over him" (John 7:43). When Jesus anointed the eyes of the blind man with the clay and opened his eyes on the Sabbath, "there was a division among them" (John

9:16). He taught that He was the door of the sheep and the Good Shepherd, and "there was again a division among the Jews because of these words" (John 10:19). The New English Bible renders this passage vividly by translating the impact of the Greek: "These words once again caused a split . . ." (NEB). Both what Jesus said and what He did caused splits repeatedly in the religious community.

The same is true for the Apostles who were also commissioned by the Holy Spirit. The book of Acts reveals that they divided not only congregations but entire cities. In Iconium the ministry of Paul and Barnabus resulted in a large body of both Jews and Gentiles becoming believers. However, those who did not believe stirred up the townspeople so that "the people of the city were divided; some sided with the Jews, and some with the apostles" (Acts 14:4). After his arrest and imprisonment in Jerusalem, Paul spoke before the chief priests and council aware that part of them were Sadducees and the other Pharisees. The Sadducees did not believe in the resurrection of the dead as did the Pharisees. He opened his defense by explaining that the true issue of the trial was the hope of the resurrection of the dead. "And when he had said this, a dissension arose between the Pharisees and the Sadducees; and the assembly was divided" (Acts 23:7). Between these two incidents lie the imprisonment at Phillippi, the expulsion at Thessalonica and the serious disturbance at Ephesus; all of this because of a committed man sent by God with the message of truth in the spirit of love.

Are we to suppose that truth in love stirs men less today, both for the will of God or against it? Hardly! A servant of God who is living a life of self-denial, filled with the love of God and who dares

speak and live the truth revealed by the Spirit of God will divide churches and cities. The mark of his validity will be his love for all men everywhere, but that great love of God demonstrated in word and deed will surely split today's nominal church congregation.

A true servant of God not only teaches a life of vital faith but experientially declares it. Every moment of every hour of every day is filled with devotion and obedience to God and a spiritual outpouring of divine love for all people. One may have occasion to hear propositionally about a wholehearted commitment to God, but when one actually meets another person who is living such a life, there is an existential encounter that demands a decision. What may have been an idealistic proposal becomes a fact to which one must relate, and such relating demands a reevaluation and appraisal of one's position and one's heart. Either this phenomenon, this revealed life, is true or it is not. If it is true, it presents the observer with a choice--to accept or reject such a life for one's self.

Jesus not only taught the Kingdom of God, He brought the Kingdom. So, also, does a servant of God or a people of God bring the Kingdom. The confrontation with God and His Kingdom is the ultimate issue of life. It demands a decision. One must surrender or rebel, commit or resist, lose one's life to find it or seek to find it and lose it.

The exemplary holy life may be an indictment or an invitation, but it surely requires response. This place of meeting between one person and another is the primary place of knowing oneself and knowing reality. This place of realized existence and true knowledge is a place of perpetual crisis where decisions regarding one's honesty must be

of perpetual crisis where decisions regarding one's honesty must be made. Does one acknowledge that there is in fact a higher life, a deeper walk, a more devoted heart, a greater experience that is here presented? Does one then surrender to the reality of that fact and abandon one's current place? Or does one in dishonesty refuse to acknowledge the reality that demands surrender and abandonment, hold to one's present position in pride, and deny or resist the challenge of a holy life? The fact is that when one encounters a life abandoned to God one encounters God, and the meeting calls for a decision to either acknowledge or disavow responsibility to God. Is it any wonder that Jesus said it was the honest heart that having heard the word, keeps it and brings forth fruit with patience; or that whoever does not receive the Kingdom of God as a little child shall not enter therein; or that it is when one loses his life that he finds it?

An encounter with God always involves a response, a decision to surrender or not to surrender to the higher love, the higher life that is sensed in Him. There is always the pull of the greater, the higher, the purer, the lovelier in God. But there is also the pull to remain in one's present place--to not acknowledge the reality of God or the need for more devotion to Him.

There may be a point in everyone's life--a crucial, monumental moment of opportunity--when a basic decision of honesty or dishonesty is made in regard to oneself and reality. From the time of this important existential moment, everything is perceived from a place of either self-centered rigidity or yieldedness to that which is beyond one's self, to the ultimate, loving Other, to the Heavenly Father. Just as a scientist must yield himself in childlike wonder to the facts of the universe,

living God and the call of Christlikeness.

When a servant of God arrives at a place with a word and a life of challenge, people are immediately confronted with the living Christ. There is a decision. There is a differentiation according to the honesty and hunger of heart. Some find great hope and the promise of fuller life in the challenge of a greater commitment to God. Others find instead a threat to their self-perception and an indictment of their shallow religious experience which they refuse to accept. This refusal is the refusal of the Lordship of Christ. The aversion to God can be tremendously strong and belligerent. It is evil in the truest sense. It brings a spiritual struggle, a struggle against God.

One cannot even begin to perceive the terrible hatred against God unless one obeys God consistently. Thus, there is very little appreciation or protection for a true servant of Jesus in most religious groups. Paul received no outward rest and protection until he journeyed to Corinth. He was able to preach freely there for eighteen months because the Lord had many people in that city (Acts 18:1-11).

When I took my first pastoral assignment after leaving seminary, I was unprepared for the reaction of some members of the congregation and some of the pastors in my area of assignment. One of the members in that congregation considered himself knowledgeable in the Scriptures, and he seriously differed with me about carnality in the believer. He opposed me vehemently from the audience declaring to the people of the congregation that when a person is saved, not only are his sins washed away by the blood of Jesus, but all carnality also. Of course, in his effort to prove his point he demonstrated the opposite. This lay leader became so incensed and verbally violent that many thought he might

bodily harm me. My wife and associate pastor would stand beside me to protect me from the threat of physical assault. The threats increased after my resignation. Charges were made against me to officers of the denomination. I was asked to appear before the national chairperson to answer these charges which had no basis whatsoever. Later I learned that I had no obligation to appear before the national leader since the meeting was called in a manner which bypassed all legal procedures set forth by the church bylaws of that state. So unfounded were the charges that even though the presiding minister sympathized with my accusers, I was exonerated on every count but one. The remaining charge stated that I had allowed false prophets to occupy the local pulpit. They were judged to be false prophets because they were ordained ministers of other denominations.

By God's grace, I was never judgmental or critical towards those opposing me; but the small and vocal opposition, coupled with the power of national leadership, rendered my ministry ineffective. The vast majority of ministers and laity who could have stopped the harassment went to neutral ground. Unable to minister or preach without facing verbal and possible physical abuse, unsupported by both state and national ministers, and receiving no help from a nice but neutral congregation, it did not take a great deal of wisdom to conclude that I had to resign and leave that pastorate.

Part of the reason I needed to know where the Lord wanted me to go in my next assignment was the knowledge that the battle was hard enough when in divine order. Where would be my protection if I got out of the will of God? In fact, if the Holy Spirit had not witnessed to my going somewhere, then I wanted out of the ministry. The discovery that

integrity and continuous obedience are met by violent opposition was new to me as far as contemporary Christianity was concerned. I was not sure that I had the strength or courage to face the fanatical, determined minority together with the neutrality of the vast majority. Once the Lord witnessed that Scott Depot was the place where I was to go, I resolved at least to go and die with a loving spirit. I thought that this assignment might lead to my death. It nearly did.

When the Scott Depot pulpit committee came to hear me preach, the man who opposed me so adamantly tried to engage them in conversation just after the morning service, but my associate pastor stopped him kindly and detained him in conversation until the visitors were with me in my study. I shall never forget, by the grace of God, the faces of those men. A minister whom I had called in the state of West Virginia had been kind enough to recommend me in spite of his reservations about how the church there would treat me. Because this pulpit committee highly valued his recommendation, they had come quickly, invited me to preach a trial sermon the next Sunday and then moved me and my family to Scott Depot after the congregation had voted for me to be the new pastor.

The devil fought fiercely even on the day of my trial sermon. One man took it upon himself to arouse me from my afternoon rest to criticize me for acknowledging the rights of women in the Church. My wife was watching us prayerfully through the window. After fifteen minutes of his verbal attack, she saw me smile, take the arm of my assailant and speak a few words to him. When I stepped back inside the house, she asked me why I had smiled. I told her in summary all that this disturbed man had said to me. She had seen me smile when he said,

"Pastor, you are not what you ought to be, but God has revealed to me that He can make you what you ought to be."

It was then that I, while still smiling, put my hand on his arm and replied, "Brother, pray for me that I will become what God wants me to be."

My response startled him so much that he broke off the conversation and left. I learned later that this person often took it upon himself to correct ministers and, most of the time, kept them tied up in conversation for hours. When he told me that I was falling short of God's will in my life but that God could bring me to maturity, I knew that he was exactly right about that matter and asked him to pray for me. Since I had been opposed for a long time and had been fought fiercely during my tenure at the other church, my wife and I would have left that afternoon had it not been for the revelation of the Holy Spirit that Scott Depot was the place for us.

The voice of God must always be the way one determines what one must do or where one must go. Then, when one proceeds toward that goal like Abraham of old, one must continue on to the Promise Land in spite of devils and good people. Most of the opposition will be from good people rather than apparent "devils," good people who have been taught that we go by circumstances when we choose a course of action. Many who do get word from Heaven as to where they should go will give up because of adverse circumstances. Nevertheless, the ensuing struggle is one of the confirming signs that one is in God's will.

It was not long before I could see the same pattern evolving at Scott Depot that had developed at the previous church. A minority of opposition began to make itself visible. I knew that if God did not do

a miracle, my ministry would terminate in two to four years. The minority of opposition would become increasingly vocal; they would find sympathetic ears in the power structure of the state ministers; the majority would go neutral or be too frightened to hold to what is right, and an abortion of the mission would take place.

Ordinarily the average minister and congregation experience a "honeymoon" period of about six months to two years. The cycle of previous problems then repeats itself challenging the pastor's leadership. Within another six months to two years after the opposing factions resurface, the pastor is forced to resign. It will not always be obvious that he is forced out, because a wise pastor will have to be one jump ahead of the opposition to keep the record of his ministry from being unfairly tarnished. The reader should know that I am the son of a very humble and loving minister. The pattern I have described above is one that characterized his ministry over and over again. Through the years, my father found this recurring set of circumstances to be the norm not only for our denomination but, also, for many other church groups as well.

It is a miracle of God that any congregation should find the pastor chosen for them by God Himself, but it is not impossible. Miracles are rare only because we do not rely on God consistently. To find God's will and to do it consistently requires a God who is willing to intervene when necessary and a person who is willing to do God's will when it is revealed. A consistent and determined attitude as to the will of God on the part of any person or persons will produce as many miracles as is necessary to establish and further the Kingdom of God. God has been willing to assist us since ancient times, but few have been

willing to follow with the right attitude of heart. The Bible tells us that "the eyes of the Lord run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to show his might in behalf of those whose heart is blameless toward him" (II Chronicles 16:9a).

Some years ago I learned that John Wesley was deeply influenced by the writings of August Hermann Francke. Francke had written a book entitled Nicodemus. Wesley was so influenced by this particular work that he carried it with him all of his ministerial life. The effect of its message upon Wesley's life explains his unflinching loyalty to a right course of action in the face of tremendous odds, especially religious opposition. The motif of this influential book was that few persons would follow the will of God past the point of conflict. In the path of every man's walk with God lies a point of conflict that usually determines if he will continue to obey the voice of God or not. The chief obstacle is the fear of man. Francke points out that the higher the religious position, the less likely it is that the person will be loyal to the revealed will of God. Until we fear God only, we will all be possessed by this malady, the fear of man. However, it is stronger in the religious person of high position because he has the most to lose. His particular religious group will threaten him with loss of prestige, position and power. At that point of conflict most all men succumb. Francke wrote:

In every case, the fear of man, whoever has it, is "a vicious thing and an idolatrous sin, which arises from unbelief, since man disregards the fear of God, and takes in hand, speaks or does an evil thing, or forbears from undertaking, speaking or doing a good thing, by only looking towards men when he ought simply to follow the Word of God and set it in his doing and

not-doing as his own rule and standard."²⁰

Francke pointed out that the fear of man is the opposite of real Christianity and, in particular, that it consists of a lack of experience of God. Perhaps his most revealing point is that "there is no disposition on the part of man in his conflicts seriously to venture upon God or to abandon himself to Him alone."²¹ The answer to the problem of the fear of man is faith in God. In essence, faith is union with God and therefore freedom from fear.

For the man who trusts in God is joined by faith with the strength of the living God and the Creator of heaven and earth in such wise that he is stronger than the whole world, be it visible or invisible.²²

The ensuing struggle is revealing and significant, but we should not permit it to deter us from doing His will. When the will of God is revealed, one must press past the point of conflict with the assurance that God's power is stronger by far than any power that opposes. If a pastor is sent by God, it is important that the congregation recognize that there will be an ensuing struggle and that this is the sign of validity. If the pastor is a loving man of truth and sent by the Holy Spirit, the congregation must fortify themselves for the conflict and be as determined as the pastor to do God's will. It is especially important that the leadership respond to that pastor. Division may come, but unity will be restored and renewal will be experienced by that

²⁰ August Hermann Francke, Nicodemus or Treatise On The Fear Of Man, (1707), Quoted from Martin Schmidt, John Wesley: A Theological Biography, Volume I (Nashville/New York: Abingdon Press), p. 142.

²¹ Ibid., p. 143.

²² Ibid., p. 144.

community of believers. Recognition of what is taking place and support of the pastor's call to commitment will bring the victory much sooner.

Most of the time the support of the congregation is determined by the response of one person. Usually there is a person in any given church group that has demonstrated reliability and trustworthiness over a number of years which has resulted in influence, esteem and confidence. The person who through faithfulness and consistency has gained the respect of the worshipping community will hold the key to the work of renewal in that particular church body. He will be the vital link between the pastor and people. The Scott Depot congregation has this kind of leader. His name is Otis Wells.

Early in my ministry here, Otis shared with me that he had been looking for a pastor who would do God's will. Also, he had been looking for a man like Loran Helm who had paid the price for his walk with God and who would not be deterred from the will of God under any circumstance. He said to me just after the ensuing struggle began to surface, "Pastor, I have been looking for you all my life. Our people have really wanted a pastor sent by God. You do God's will and let me get between you and the devil." He was to be tested to the limit for that stand, but he has never changed one iota in his resolution. The majority of the congregation followed until they could really know what was in my heart. The initial vote for my coming had been ninety-eight percent. After seven years the vote of confidence was one hundred percent. Otis was the man who stood in the gap until the congregation could know me fully. Because of his courageous stand, we were able to begin and continue our trips abroad, open our day care and Christian school, add a minister to our staff who was not ordained by our

denomination, and embark on the adventure of close ties with the Jewish community at home as well as abroad.

The importance of one key man believing the report cannot be overstated. Often an entire church community is kept from following the leadership of the Holy Spirit because one man, or a few, block the way by virtue of the position of power they hold. How important it is for that key person to know God and to commit himself to do God's will with all his heart.

As the pressures and persecutions increased in the first five or six years, the love and support of this key layman, together with the overwhelming majority of the congregation, enabled me to overcome in the struggle that came after my decision to follow only the voice of God. That struggle involved years of opposition from several state ministers, a small but powerful minority within the congregation which refused and resisted my leadership, and virtually no backing from the national denominational leaders.

I must impress on the reader the tremendous opposition that follows when any one person or group determines to do only the will of God. It is important for all sincere and honest persons to realize this so that they will see it for what it is, a sign of validity. One's attitude must be like the Apostles, who after being thrown in prison and beaten, were found "rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name" (Acts 5:41) of Jesus.

In the beginning of my ministry at Scott Depot, I would often marvel at the terrible hatred and violent opposition expressed from different sources. I shall not specifically describe the truly evil acts and demonic opposition experienced during the first five or six

years of our ministry at Scott Depot, an attack that came especially through members of the clergy. For one reason, it is hardly believable until one experiences it for oneself. More importantly, there is a lesson to be learned from such an experience. It is the lesson of love--forgiving, redeeming love. Nothing should be expressed which would be contrary to the realization of that love. For no matter how difficult the battle or how fierce the opposition, the response must always be one of love. All the while one is being true to God's will, one must be true to His character, abandoned to Him, filled with Christ and His suffering but undefeatable love. What is a call to spiritual commitment if not a call to Christ's love, and how valid is our call if our reaction to resistance or even opposition is contrary to holy love? There is no room for a "persecution complex" here, no room for separatism or elitism. There is only room for a consuming but proper passion to be consciously and deliberately devoted to the will of God and to see how love can be made real and demonstrated in practice. Even with such passion and devotion, or perhaps because of it, there will be great opposition to the servants of God. Yet I have observed that men of God are known more by what they do not say than for what they do say concerning opposition and persecution.

The mystery of this demonic and wicked opposition is clarified by the Scripture given earlier concerning those who were found "rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name" (Acts 5:41). The suffering is a result of the name of Jesus or the person of God. This battle is not a personal one. As Paul said in the letter to the Ephesians: "We are not contending against flesh and blood, but against the principalities, against the powers, against the

world rulers of this present darkness, against the spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places" (Ephesians 6:12). The devil hates God as much now as he did two thousand years ago. The war is one that rages in the heavenlies, and that war is acted out in the human arena. John the Revelator saw this reality and wrote, "Now war arose in heaven. . . ." (Revelation 12:7). Paul instructs the saints to put on the whole armor of God to be able to stand against the evil schemes of the adversary.

The more God is revealed in one's life and the more He is revealed in the life of the Church, the greater the opposition by those who have given themselves over to the carnal mind. The Holy Scriptures tell us that the carnal mind hates God and cannot by its nature be subject to the law of God. The real shock comes in the realization that the saints are not so much themselves opposed as is Christ in them. Throughout the early years of walking with Loran Helm, I saw without question that his loving, uncritical manner, coupled with the highest ethical standards, ought to have made him the most acceptable person in Christendom. Yet the opposite was true. As in the days of Jesus and the Apostles, the presence of Christ in Loran's life caused tremendous upheaval and divisions. The response to him would often be extreme and out of proportion to the size or nature of the point of opposition that a spiritual variable was the only explanation. Sometimes I would enter a home or a church with him and watch the fierce opposition develop even when he spoke not a word. I could see that the carnal man does not oppose the carnal man but always reacts to oppose the spiritual man. It was not Loran Helm that was hated but the living Christ within him.

One of my biggest questions in the beginning days of Scott Depot

was did I really want to become like Christ? I remember praying, "Oh, Lord, it is not human personality that carnal men hate and oppose. It is You. I don't know if I want to become like You if men are going to hate me as they hate You." But, of course, I had no choice. To do God's will is Christlikeness and that means suffering and persecution. In fact the only sure way we can be Christlike is to do God's will. We cannot be as loving, kind, or compassionate as He was, but we can be exactly like Him in doing God's will. This brings the Kingdom of God to earth (Thy Kingdom come, Thy will be done on earth as it is in Heaven). The Apostle Peter writes that our souls are purified when we obey the truth (I Peter 1:22). To do God's will, therefore, is to become more like Jesus.

The key to endurance and triumph, however, is what we focus on during the struggle. If we keep our eyes on the struggle, it will consume us. The writer of the letter to the Hebrews encourages us to consider Jesus. He endured the cross for the joy that was set before Him. The goal of God, His will and His Kingdom should be ever before us. The struggle, if noticed much at all, ought simply to be a sign of validity and a cue for rejoicing that we are counted worthy to suffer for His name. Our weapons are mighty through God to the pulling down of strongholds, and if God be for us, who can stand against us.

During those early years I developed heart trouble, suffered in the nervous system and experienced weeks and months of sleepless nights. At the time I thought it was the hardest struggle a person could endure, but I was to learn that when the conflict is won, in the outward circumstances, there remains an inner battle that is more difficult than the outward one. Outward battles work a wonder within the soul. If we

respond rightly to the opposition by keeping a good spirit, looking to Jesus, the Author and Finisher of our faith, and do not indulge in criticizing anyone, God will use those negative circumstances to transform our lives. Paul writes that we should glory in our sufferings, because suffering produces perseverance, perseverance produces character and character produces hope. While we are in the midst of the battle, God is transforming our own lives and hearts.

Throughout history the dynamics of renewal produce the same pattern over and over again. A vital, spiritual group of people increasingly substitute ritual for genuine experience with God which produces dead formalism. A man sent from God will call for repentance and reformation. One group, often older and more established, will reject the attempt at renewal. Another group will excitedly embrace the adventure of vital commitment, thus producing a remnant after which the cycle begins all over again.

An important point must here be made. The attitude among some renewal theologians is that the Holy Spirit can never really work with the older, rejecting group again. However, it is not the intention of the Holy Spirit to leave the professed people of God without hope. There is a great deal of hope for all the professed Church. The rejected remnant must play a vital role in restoration.

The small independent groups do have their purpose. They restore and preserve the image of Christ that has been so terribly marred by the larger bodies. When Richard Wurmbrand was converted to Christianity, all the great Christian confessions seemed to him like Babylon. They had no resemblance to the Church that Jesus left behind. He found the children of God in the denominations, but he could not find

the face of Christ in their corporate expression. In his book, Christ on the Jewish Road, he explains:

God's children, no matter to what denomination they belonged, were close to me. But I have felt most at my ease among those who have left the great denominations. The hard facts I discovered in the big denominations destroyed the picture of Christ which I had in my heart: I rediscovered this picture in the small Christian groups.²³

Even though Richard Wurmbrand points out that the image of Christ cannot be found in the denominations, it is significant to note that he is a Lutheran pastor today, not the pastor of a small remnant. When he came to Scott Depot, one of the first things he said was that we had a vital Christian fellowship. Later, he pointedly asked me why I had left the denomination of my spiritual birth. (Actually, I did not leave my denomination. The ministers of West Virginia had excluded me on the basis of my philosophy. That philosophy, in essence, is being written in this book.) I did not take the time to explain the dynamics involved or try to defend my actions. I simply responded that he, Richard Wurmbrand, answered the question himself in his devotional book, Reaching Toward the Heights. He looked at me and asked me to cite the passage that he had written. I read from his book the following:

Our attitude toward the church has to be ambivalent. Whoever has God as his father, has the church as his mother and owes her obedience and love. A mother can go mad, too. The church is not only a divine institution; she is also constituted of men who can commit grave sins in her name. Top church leaders are not exempt from this possibility. So obedience toward the church has a limit which natural reason and the guidance of the Holy Spirit will show you.²⁴

²³ Richard Wurmbrand, Christ on the Jewish Road, (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1970), p. 47.

²⁴ Richard Wurmbrand, Reaching Toward the Heights, (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1977), December 9th entry.

He smiled and acknowledged the truth of his own writing.

When excluded from my own denomination, the Lord revealed that we were to call ourselves the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship. In truth we are just a small part of that great Church of God created by Jesus Himself. Rather than start a new denomination, we have chosen to be just a fellowship of believers attempting to give a clear picture of Christ by following the voice of God within our own hearts and trying to love as Christ loves. Our purpose, however, is not to forget the larger confessions. The Apostle Paul makes it clear in the letter to the Romans that the remnant has been formed because the larger portion of the body has been cut off through unbelief. But the purpose of the remnant is that mercy may be granted to the larger body that rejected renewal.

At this point the reader may be wondering how the letter to the Romans can be relevant to the division within the Christian Church. For two and one-half years I spoke to the believers at the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship from the book of Romans in response to the leading of the Holy Spirit. As I preached through the letter, it became increasingly clear that the real issue of faith was not just an issue between Gentile and Jew but between any vital remnant and a larger unbelieving body. Paul tells us that the Jew, the larger body of professed faith in God, had rejected the remnant who had believed the revelation of God in that day. Even though that particular issue will be resolved at some future day, he points out that the remnant is to be the channel of mercy to the larger unbelieving body. Here we see that the remnant not only gives a clear picture of Christ but also becomes the very channel through which the Holy Spirit restores and renews all

the people who profess to be the people of God. One might miss the implications in a surface reading of that great writing, but a deeper reading of that explanation of true faith will reveal that the dynamics today are the same as they were then. Then, as now, dead ritualism had gripped the professed people of God. The Apostle points out that rite, ritual and religious ceremony will not suffice for salvation--only a vital faith that hears the voice of God and obeys. Although one is justified at the point of believing God as Abraham did of old, that belief is intrinsically obedient. Faith is entire reliance on God for all matters of life. Religiosity cannot be substituted for a faith that hears and heeds the voice of God. Only those who walk after the Spirit can overcome the carnal mind which hates God and cannot be subjected to the law of God. The people who follow the Spirit and hear the voice of Christ become a remnant with a vital connection with God. The purpose of that remnant is to be a channel of mercy and restoration. To this end Paul gives the great invitation. To the church of Rome composed of both Jew and Gentile, he pleads with all his heart. Listen to what is one of the greatest calls made by anyone in Scripture to the believing people of God:

I appeal to you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship. Do not be conformed to this world but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that you may prove what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect (Romans 12:1,2).

Only a remnant who becomes a living sacrifice can be a channel of mercy for the large unbelieving body who have substituted ritual for a vital faith. To be used of God for this great purpose demands that any body of believers die entirely to their own self-interests and

prepare to become a channel of mercy to those who do not hear or heed the voice of God.

As I think over the words I have just written, I feel compelled to share something that I believe would bring renewal more quickly to the larger professed body. The groundwork has been laid earlier in the chapter for this final point on spiritual struggle. Even as I have written, I have not sought to use a strategy. Even the writing of this book has been a mission that has been unfolding. There are real men of faith throughout the larger confessions. Perhaps there are not many but there are, no doubt, men like Otis Wells in the larger church bodies who could prevent the vital remnants from being cut off from the main body. A struggle would ensue, certainly, but if the men in power would support those pastors and remnant groups, they could be protected and assisted. The purpose of the remnant is to make the larger body jealous and to prepare to be a channel of mercy in renewal and restoration. It is not God's purpose for the remnant to be cut off. Paul cited the Macedonian churches to the Corinthians as examples to emulate. Most pastors and laymen cease to consider the possibility of a particular group being a genuine renewal group because the power structure and the persons in authority cut them off and thus the intended challenge is forfeited. It does not have to be that way. The whole Church belongs to God. If the Lord can find a person or persons to stand in the gap, He will show Himself strong in behalf of those whose hearts are perfect toward Him. My great shock has been to discover that virtually no one in a position of power and authority will stand up for men or groups of renewal. I have had several persons of great influence to acknowledge the validity of the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship but absolutely no one to stand for

us when it really counted. The thesis of August Hermann Francke that the fear of man is stronger in positions of power has been proven over and over again. Virtually no one will even take the position of Gamaliel, who said unto the Sanhedrin with reference to the early church:

So in the present case I tell you, keep away from these men and let them alone; for if this plan or this undertaking is of men, it will fail; but if it is of God, you will not be able to overthrow them. You might even be found opposing God! (Acts 5:38,39).

That position, I would think, would be the least possible one for keeping integrity.

An example of the kind of support and encouragement that I am pleading for is found in J. Oswald Sanders book, The Holy Spirit and His Gifts.²⁵ Sanders wrote in 1940:

The Vicar of Christ, as the Holy Spirit has been called, earnestly desires to administer His beneficent yet holy rule in the Church, but unfortunately in our day the will of the majority has almost entirely displaced the will of the Spirit. The members of the Body are more and more usurping the prerogatives of the Spirit But once allow Him His rightful position, however, and churches will begin to throb with new spiritual life.

Those are powerful and important words. Sanders then goes on to give an example of this profound but simple truth. It also illustrates perfectly my plea at the close of this chapter that I must let Dr. Sanders give it in his own words:

Dr. A. T. Pierson told of a young vicar in England who found himself in charge of a parish that had extreme ritualistic practices, and with them secular tendencies equally pronounced. The spirit of prayer and the Spirit of God had little recognition or administrative control.

²⁵J. Oswald Sanders, The Holy Spirit and His Gifts, (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1940), pp. 78-80.

The congregation was large and outward signs of prosperity abundant, but the new vicar felt it was all a deceptive facade and that there was little true spiritual life in the church. With much prayer he began to preach against compromise with the world and adoption of worldly schemes, and insisted on a Scriptural, prayerful, and spiritual walk and service.

The church began to empty. So rapid was the decline in the congregation that a deputation of twelve men representing the officers and others went to the bishop to protest against the vicar's methods. The bishop sent his wife, a gifted woman, to visit the parish and especially the vicar.

She was kindly received, and enquired his reasons for the course he was pursuing in demolishing the work as he found it in the parish. He frankly showed how far the former ways were from Scripture. Then, kneeling with the bishop's wife he earnestly sought light from above. In the midst of his praying, the bishop's wife said, "Pray no longer. You are right and I am wrong."

The vicar went on with his reforms until there were few left to reform. One morning he found only two persons present. They were in sympathy, however, and in place of the usual service, they spent an hour and a half in prayer. They pleaded with God to take off them the burden of responsibility, and Himself take charge of the Church.

A powerful work of the Spirit at once began. The firstfruits were the twelve men who had waited on the bishop to have the vicar removed. All were converted. The church filled up with a new congregation in part, and in part with a transformed body of people, who formerly were entirely worldly in spirit.

Prayer became a prevailing habit. The Holy Spirit was recognized as the presiding Officer in all church life. The gospel was preached simply, and God's blessing conspicuously rested on all the work.

Later, the bishop himself visited the parish. He inquired of one of the church wardens who was a mechanic the number of communicants.

"We never count the communicants," he replied, "but when the Lord's Supper is celebrated, few, if any go out, and the church is always full."

"But," said the bishop, "how do you keep your communicants together seeing you have no guilds and societies and festivals?"

"Well, I'll tell you," replied the simple working man. "Our vicar first gets his people soundly converted, then he gets them filled with the Holy Spirit, and then the Holy Spirit keeps them, and we don't have to keep them at all."

Turning to his chaplain, the bishop said, "We have nothing like this in the diocese." This church supported several missionaries, and using New Testament methods, the vicar had more money than was needed.

A prominent Christian whose work involved him in wide

travel, as he watched the development of this church, said that he knew of nothing that appeared to so closely resemble and reproduce apostolic times. And it was the result of recognizing and according to the Holy Spirit His rightful place in the church.

The bishop and his wife were spiritually sensitive and courageous people. History tells us that persons like these are extremely rare. But it is encouraging that someone stood in the gap for this humble pastor who was determined to do God's will at any cost. Considering that a consensus prevails in most religious circles that the larger confessions are spiritually lifeless, isn't it time for those who know the Spirit of God to stand for right no matter what the cost? Usually, losing one's life begins in the confession of faith in which one finds himself. Are we to think that the Sanhedrin were any more or less the way we all are? No, they were the brightest and the best. They did not have pointed ears and beady eyes. Nevertheless, they did not have the courage, honesty and integrity to take their stand for John the Baptist or Jesus. Yet Nicodemus had reported to Jesus that all the Sanhedrin knew He came from God (John 3:2).

When we start to walk with God, a struggle will ensue that at times will seem to shake the foundations of our very soul. But it cannot shake the Kingdom of Almighty God. If we are to bring that Kingdom to earth, we must be willing to respond with faith and love and courage to the struggle that follows our unflinching commitment to the will of God.

Chapter 5

The Unfulfilled Dream

We shall nobly save, or meanly lose, the last best hope of earth.
---Abraham Lincoln

When the Apostle Paul wrote the letter to the church at Rome, he shared the dream of his heart--the uniting of all the people of God, both Jew and Gentile. It was an unfulfilled dream for him because the differences between Jew and Gentile were never really surrendered to the will of God and therefore unnecessarily continued to play a part in dividing the Church.

Once, on the day called Pentecost when the Church was entirely Jewish, it experienced oneness. Luke writes that "the company of those who believed were of one heart and soul" (Acts 4:32a). As a result, the power of conviction and transformation was so great that three thousand were added to the Church in one day. In just a few days more, the number of men alone grew to five thousand. Conceivably, if one adds women and children to that number, the Church could have reached twenty-five or thirty thousand people in just a few days. The exact number can only be a matter of conjecture; the important thing to note is how such power of conviction for conversion came to pass. It happened because one hundred twenty people became one in mind and heart.

The power of God released through likemindedness was so great that not only were honest hearts irresistibly drawn, but that which was

contrary to the will of God in heart and company was repelled. The greediness and deceitfulness of Ananias and Sapphira were so contrary to the purity of heart and singleness of purpose required by the Kingdom of God that they could not live in the midst of such purifying power.

There was no significant sign of division in the spiritual community until the Grecian Jews complained against the Hebraic Jews because their widows were being overlooked in the daily distribution of food. Although this problem was handled administratively, there is no indication that the oneness which had prevailed at the beginning was ever restored. The Jewish church scattered abroad after Stephen's death leaving only the Apostles in Jerusalem. Later, a church was reconstituted in Jerusalem under the leadership of Peter; James, the Lord's brother; and John. But the initial, tremendous, corporately released power of God was diminished.

Paul's marvelous conversion on the road to Damascus, together with his unparalleled revelation from God concerning the reality of one new man in Christ where there had once been two, enjoined the Apostle to work fervently toward the oneness of God's people. Peter's vision at Joppa and resultant visit to the home of Cornelius served to confirm and support the plan of God for all people to be one in this new Kingdom of Faith. However, through the years, the differences and prejudices would threaten and divide as the vision of oneness would fade. The background of Paul's letter to Rome reveals what appears to be a magnanimous effort on the part of Paul to bring healing to the growing division between Jew and Gentile within the Church itself. He had urged the Gentile churches of Macedonia and Achaia to raise an offering over a period of time to relieve the poor Hebrews connected with the church in Jerusalem. Their

generous offering would prove the sincerity of their faith and love to the mother church and the validity of Paul's ministry to the Gentiles. He asked the church of Rome to pray that the offering would be accepted and that he would be delivered from unbelievers in Judea. The revealing comment that the issue is a Jewish-Gentile one, even in the Church, is found in the rationale for the offering stated in the Roman letter: "For if the Gentiles have shared in the Jews' spiritual blessings, they owe it to the Jews to share with them their material blessings" (Romans 15:27 NIV). The offering was accepted indicating that the church of Jerusalem regarded the Gentile ministry as valid. However, since the church there contained few or no Gentile members, the issue of oneness could never really be tested between Jews and Gentiles. After A.D. 70 the church of Jerusalem, having fled from the city soon to be destroyed, is never heard from again. Paul's hope for the Jerusalem church was that they would accept the principle of oneness, but his aim for the Roman church was that they would be a demonstration of oneness that would result in their becoming a channel of mercy to restore the unbelieving people of God. Though Paul was in chains when he arrived at Rome, his vision had not dimmed at all. This is especially evident in the prison epistles of Ephesians and Colossians. Central to the writing of these letters is a picture of the Church as a single, functioning body created out of Jew and Gentile and equipped by the ministers for an engagement in spiritual conflict. The goal was the unity of the faith resulting in the fullness of Christ.

The oneness of the Church was also the chief concern of Christ in His high priestly prayer recorded in John 17. Jesus prayed for those who had believed on Him and for those of us who would believe their

message--that all may be one. The strongest words of His prayer are recorded in the twenty-second and the twenty-third verses of that chapter. He had already prayed for all of the Church to be one, but now He prays for absolute oneness and then reveals the purpose of that oneness:

The glory which thou has given me I have given to them, that they may be one even as we are one, I in them and thou in me, that they may become perfectly one, so that the world may know that thou hast sent me and hast loved them even as thou hast loved me (John 17:22,23).

Jesus prayed for His Church, the vital remnant, to become one in order that the world would believe that He had been sent by His Father. The purpose of oneness is for the world around us to be converted and transformed. The oneness of God's people is the key to the world believing in the reality of God, the healing of His love, the efficacy of His grace, the centrality of His spiritual Kingdom and the essentiality and blessing of commitment to His will. No thinking person can deny the power of a committed life that is consistent in winning, over a period of time, family and friends to the reign of God. But the kind of power that is released from a Church that is one with the Father and the Son is something only rarely seen in history. Nevertheless, it is central in the teaching of the Apostle Paul, and it is the thing for which Jesus earnestly prayed. This is the power we need released today. To a measure this is what the great revivals teach us, revivals such as the great Welsh revival of 1904 when 100,000 souls were converted in six weeks.

The lesson of the Roman and Ephesian letters is that a corporate body must give itself as a living sacrifice in order that the great division among believing and unbelieving people will be healed. These

principles set forth by the Apostle Paul must be applied to the divided Church today. The Church has to be restored and united before it can become an effective channel of mercy to the world. Groups which are forced to become a remnant must be refined further until the image of Christ is clear to honest and seeking hearts. When the face of Christ appears perfectly, that remnant will be a channel through which the power of God will revive and renew the confessing but unbelieving majority. Jesus prayed for it in His high priestly prayer, and it came to pass on the day of Pentecost.

The spiritual oneness of God's people is caused and characterized by certain very important corporate spiritual qualities. God's true people have a holy purity, a divine love and a genuine joy that are the means and manifestation of vitality and unity.

Hearts must be pure in purpose and nature, emptied of carnal and self-seeking characteristics. The so-called "major" or "worldly" sins are not so much what are hindering the Church in her mission. We should all know that murder, lying, stealing, cheating or sexual promiscuity are wrong. The sins of the spirit are the ones that block oneness and the working of God through His people. Impurities such as unrighteous anger, envy, selfishness, spite, resentfulness, contentiousness, argumentativeness, trustlessness, foolishness, jesting, negligence, discontent, jealousy, covetousness, murmuring and complaining must be surrendered to God and cleansed from our hearts so that He can find a people to whom He can really trust Himself, His power and His Kingdom.

God's people are also filled with Christ's divine love and are consistent in its expression. Their love is a love that is sincere, redemptive and constant--a love that is never critical, judgmental or

faultfinding. One of the important keys to oneness is the absence of a critical or faultfinding spirit among God's people. There should be such a sincere and constant love that every member of a community of faith would know that he would never be criticized by others when he was not present. Never! Perfect, non-critical, forgiving love offers healing and hope for all members of a church body. When any person sees the great need of his own heart, he will not, he dares not speak evil of anyone else. John Wesley defines evil speaking this way: "For evil-speaking is neither more nor less than speaking evil of an absent person; relating something evil which was really done or said by one that is not present when it is related."²⁶ Usually the one speaking evil of another is trying to elevate himself above the one he is criticizing all the while having the greater evil in his own heart. The practice of speaking evil is one of the chief reasons the Church is not able to come to oneness or to convince the world of the love of Christ. Only by losing themselves to the adventure of loving God and doing His will, only by denying themselves and following Christ can a body of believers exhibit Christlike love. Such love is essential for the Church to know the plan and the power of God in bringing hope to the world.

God's people should be known, as well, for their joy and praise. Praise is an indicator and a stimulator of joy and trust. God is "enthroned on the praises of Israel" (Psalm 22:3), and He is enthroned on the praises in the hearts of His children who walk with Him in trust.

²⁶ John Wesley, "The Cure of Evil Speaking," The Works of John Wesley, ed. Albert C. Outler, II (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1985), p. 252.

When He is, there will be a spontaneous and continuous outpouring of thanksgiving for all of God's blessing in our lives, for the major miracles of intervention and the smallest signs of His care.

Purity of heart, divine love and genuine joy are not marginal issues in our mission. They are central to individual Christian experience and to the vitality of a body of believers. They are crucial to oneness and to the demonstration of the reality of God to the world. There is an experience with God which fulfills the longing of every honest heart. This experience is the true expression the world needs to see.

The implications are staggering and the responsibility upon any remnant group is awesome. One may find himself saying, "This is impossible!" True, it is impossible for any group to bring this to pass. However, the impossibility of a group to bring revival and renewal is one of the first lessons to learn before renewal can be accomplished. Just this lesson alone would remove most of the advertisements in our newspapers which announce spring and fall "revivals." Evan Roberts, of the Wales Revival of 1904, was able to tell his mother and friends that God was about to send a revival but only because the Holy Spirit told him so.²⁷ It seems to me to be dangerous to place an advertisement in the newspaper any time announcing revival and then not produce one. Yet this has taken place numerous times during my forty-eight years as a minister's son. No revival has resulted. We cannot produce it. "With men it is impossible, but not

²⁷James A. Stewart, Invasion of Wales by the Spirit Through Evan Roberts, (Fort Washington, Pennsylvania: Christian Literature Crusade, 1970), pp. 28, 31.

with God; for all things are possible with God" (Mark 10:27). Jesus also said it this way, "All things are possible to him who believes" (Mark 9:23). Revival is impossible for man to bring to pass. However, it is not impossible for God who responds to those who believe and to those who commit themselves to the spiritual requisites. If the conditions are met, the laws of renewal and revival are as steadfast as the laws which govern the universe. If God did it once, He can do it again. He is able to revive any group, and keep them revived, if that group will simply follow Him.

Few churches, fellowships or groups have ever consistently followed Christ. Few have followed anyone who is following Christ. Many have made proud boasts about the priesthood of believers, implying that each person himself is following Christ. To be able to hear the voice of God directly and consistently is surely a worthy goal, but the letter to Ephesians informs us that God has given the Church Apostles, Prophets, Evangelists, Pastors and Teachers "to equip the saints . . . until we all attain . . . unity . . . faith . . . knowledge . . . mature manhood . . . fulness of Christ" (Ephesians 4:12,13). This clearly means that after one believes it is important to be guided, trained, prepared and equipped, that we might come to maturity in our walk with God.

Keep in mind that I could find no one in my entire religious life who could hear the voice of God and follow that voice consistently. Dr. Trueblood once said in a chapel service during my graduate training, "The next best thing to being great is to walk with the great." I can think of nothing greater than following God. I wanted to do it. My

parents and church had created the desire within me to do it. But I did not know how to get started. Something was blocking the voice of God from speaking to me regularly. I recognized that He had spoken to me a few times. I know it was the Holy Spirit who convicted me of my sins and who gave me the witness of the Spirit as to the assurance of my salvation. I knew that God was speaking to me in the Bible, but I was not able to discern the specifics of God's will as to when to leave seminary and what church to pastor. The Bible and the spiritual classics and biographies taught me that a man or woman could walk with God closely and consistently. Any man walking with God is great. Therefore, when I found the man who was really doing it, I just did what Dr. Trueblood and the Apostle Paul asked me to do. I followed that man. As I followed him I began to notice that he, too, was in search of something. I was in search of a man, but the man for whom I searched was in search of men. Like the Apostle Paul, he was in search of persons who would be willing to be at one with the Father and the Son. Amazingly, all of the greats in my life have been in search of that fellowship of persons who would submit themselves as a group to the Lordship of Christ. The amazing thing is that both Loran Helm and Elton Trueblood have the same dream, just as did the Apostle Paul--the dream of finding "the company of the committed." What is so very sad is that the dream is as yet unfulfilled. They, like Abraham of old, are looking for a city with foundations whose architect and builder is God.

I was encouraged to write this book by Dr. Trueblood and Dr. Newby because there are signs of life at Scott Depot. Their suggestion was confirmed by the Holy Spirit. There is promise here. I myself realize that vital Christianity has surfaced in this small but important

fellowship and that, if nourished and cultivated, the image of Christ will become clear and could result in a revival that could last until Messiah comes.

Whatever signs of true Christianity may be here, it is because my people have followed me as I have followed one who is following God. When the Lord baptized Loran Helm in the Holy Spirit in 1942, a revival began in his heart and life that has lasted to this very day. The vital fellowship that has resulted here is a result of His equipping us for works of service until we reach oneness with the Father and the Son. I have had a part in it, of course, but my role has been much like Timothy under Paul. The secret of Timothy's ministry, I believe, was his devotion to the vision and revelation of the Apostle Paul. Jesus repeats over and over again that if one is to find his life he must first lose it. I did that when I came to Scott Depot. I lost membership in my denomination, my good health and all apparent signs of recognition and success. The loss did not seem very great though, because of the joy of doing God's will.

Then I continued to lose my life in another man's vision. I seldom thought of building my own career. Experience has taught me that following the Lordship of Christ will lead to losing one's life anywhere under any circumstances. Dr. Trueblood has often said, "Soak yourselves in the great models." Of course, he was speaking primarily of the biographies and writings of the great saints. But he himself has sought the fellowship of some of the greatest men of our day. The greatest lessons in life are learned by sitting at the feet of the master teachers. Socrates never wrote anything himself, but those who sat at his feet wrote under the impact of his teaching and his example. The

fact that he lived what he taught so inspired Plato and Xenophon, his most renowned students, that all of history has been shaped and influenced by their writings. Alexander Whyte, in his lectures on Socrates, tells the story of Xenophon who, when he was a young man, met the great philosopher Socrates one day in a narrow lane. Socrates put his stick across the lane to prevent him from passing. As Socrates blocked the youth, he asked him if he knew where this and that of the necessities of life could be found. After the youth had answered, Socrates then asked him if he knew where men were made good and virtuous. Confessing he did not know, Socrates said to him: "Follow me and learn these things."²⁸ Neither Elton Trueblood, Richard Wurmbrand, nor Loran Helm ever said to me "follow me"; but, in effect, the Apostle Paul was telling all of us to do this over and over again when he wrote, "follow me as I follow Christ." The principle is this: follow the man who has revelation from God. If he is following the Holy Spirit consistently, there is no better teacher. This could be called the theology of biography. It is the profitable, pedagogical premise of one soul warming itself up against the fires of another.

I am aware that there are dangers involved in this approach to mission, but those dangers detract not at all from its validity. There may be and are thousands of shallow or even counterfeit ministries. However, to see something counterfeit should tell us that the real thing is somewhere. A true minister of Jesus will never place you in bondage or commit the ethical breaches intrinsic in the cult personalities.

²⁸ Alexander Whyte, The Nature of Angels, (Grand Rapids: Baker Book House, 1976), p. 37.

If that person is following God, you may follow him because he will exhibit godly qualities in public and in private. God loves us with an unconditional love--so will he. God lets us do our own thing even if it is wrong--so will the godly minister. But, like God, he will attempt to persuade, teach, demonstrate and convince you of the holy life, a life that will result in true mission.

A life that is led of God will harmonize with the written Word. The leading of the Holy Spirit will never contradict the Word of God written. His revelation is always holy, consistent and true.

I could have written this book without really getting to the heart of the matter, but our age is desperate and at the brink of destruction. We must experience renewal soon or perish. Many observers have written or spoken that there is evidence of true spiritual vitality at Scott Depot, and through the years, the pressure has increased to share what is taking place here and how it came to be. In 1982 Senator Robert C. Byrd visited Scott Depot Christ Fellowship and was so impressed that he invited me to be the Visiting Chaplain of the United States Senate on July 15, 1982. His remarks concerning his impression of the fellowship are printed in the Congressional Record for that day. Some of those remarks are as follows:

Never have I enjoyed the experience of speaking in a church more than when I spoke at the Reverend Mr. Hogue's church at Scott Depot. I was impressed by the spirit of fellowship that obviously is there in that church during the meeting.

I was impressed by the number of young people in the church and by the enthusiasm, and the vigor, and by the intensity of feelings when they sang.

In this church there is a great adult choir of excellently trained voices. There is a great youth choir of equally excellently trained voices. The young people very actively participate in the worship service.

So this is a church that has its roots really deep in

the humanity of the surrounding area. The future is bright because it has future generations involved in the church, involved in its songs, and involved in its everyday workings. The pianist is absolutely excellent.

I compliment the Reverend Mr. Hogue on the work he is doing, on the leadership he is demonstrating at that church. It is a leadership that can very well be emulated by many other churches throughout the land.²⁹

Dr. James R. Newby gave the 1986 Indiana Yearly Meeting Quaker Lecture. Its title was "The Dynamics of Transformation." On page seven of that lecture, which is now in print, he uses the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship as an example of one church where transformation is taking place:

Just to the west of Charleston, West Virginia, is a small community called Scott Depot. In this small town is a church that stands as a beacon to all who are endeavoring to live in Christian community. I have had the privilege of speaking there a few times, and my family and I are always anxious to find a free period of time when we can go there to visit. The pastor is a dear friend, and with whom I traveled to England last year in our Yokefellow "Great Minds Tour." I always come home from my experience in that Scott Depot Fellowship completely renewed and with a devout concern that other Christian communities discover the secret of that kind of love for one another. It is not easy to describe what occurs there, but I can tell you that those wonderful people love each other so much, that they count their individual wealth and happiness as secondary to their life within that beloved community. I have said to myself, "This is Early Christianity revived!" "This is what Christ meant when He said that people will know that we are His disciples if we have love, for one another." The first and the most basic ingredient of community life in a Christian context is the love that we share with each other. I have seen this love demonstrated in a few places, of which Scott Depot is pre-eminent, and where it is present, transformation does, indeed, occur.³⁰

²⁹U.S., Congressional Record, 97th Congress, Second Session, (1982), Volume 128, No. 91, S8303-S8304.

³⁰James R. Newby, "The Dynamics of Transformation," Indiana Yearly Meeting Quaker Lecture, Earlham College, August 10, 1986, p. 7.

In the previous year, Dr. Trueblood wrote the following about his visit here in the June 1985 issue of the "Quarterly Yoke Letter":

In the fellowship which I have mentioned the pastor remained seated nearly all of the time, apparently determined to draw out the powers of the members, so far as possible. Vocal participation by members of the congregation was common, and clearly expected. The offering, though not preceded by any pressure, averages about \$7,000 each time the congregation meets on Sunday morning. This is because there is almost no token giving, most of the people actually contributing one tenth of their income to the Christian Cause. Though the participants are far from affluent, their giving is so generous that they support a variety of missions with striking generosity. Because of their spirit they have no financial problem. When I left, they handed to me a check for \$1,000 to support the Yokefellow Movement, and plenty was left over for other causes. When time came to greet strangers and visitors, the experience was not a mere gesture, but was an unhurried sharing of their lives. Strangers were expected to remain seated, while members stood and approached, not merely those who were close at hand, but persons seated at a distance, including those on the platform.

My overwhelming conclusion, as I gathered with those modest people, was that they really love one another. They are not separated individuals, each tending to his own business, and following his own interests, but persons who feel responsibility for each other's lives.³¹

The above validations are cited in the hope that the reader will be persuaded to consider seriously the spiritual elements which have evoked these extraordinary comments. When Nathaniel heard that Jesus was from Nazareth yet was declared by Philip to be the anointed one that Moses and the prophets wrote about, he astonishingly asked, "Can anything good come out of Nazareth?" (John 1:46). Philip wisely responded, "Come and see." These reputable men whom I have cited above have come to Scott Depot, and they have observed at least the beginnings of renewal. Vital Christianity is often viewed as abnormal in religious society. In order to persuade men of validity, credible witnesses are

³¹D. Elton Trueblood, "Quarterly Yoke Letter," (Richmond, Indiana,) Volume XXVII, Number 2, June, 1985.

important. Perhaps such trustworthy testimony will convince someone of the genuineness and validity of the work of God here. Then, in finding how God has been able to work in this fellowship, someone will be convinced that, indeed, the strategy of men has failed us and that, as we are trying to learn at Scott Depot, we must leave the strategy to the Holy Spirit because He is the only One who can show us the way.

One of the most significant observations that genuine renewal is taking place and that Early Christianity is being revived at Scott Depot came from two important Christian leaders. Each made the same observation almost a decade apart. In the mid-seventies Richard Wurmbbrand visited our congregation. I had been made aware of his fourteen years of suffering and torture when I read an article about him in the late sixties in National Review. Sometime later I heard him in person when he spoke in a neighboring city. I eagerly read his biography titled Christ In The Communist Prisons. I soon realized that this beloved Lutheran pastor was one of the greatest Christians in our time. It took some years to succeed in bringing him and his radiant wife Sabina to Scott Depot, but the Lord brought it to pass. During the course of a Thanksgiving weekend visit, which involved dining, fellowship and considerable time spent together, he commented to one of my associate pastors at a time when I was absent. "I have been all over the world. Before my imprisonment I had an associate to help me care for about three hundred people. However, not over the world nor in my own parish, have I seen the closeness and the harmony that I see here at Scott Depot among your ministers. Explain to me how five pastors are as one." Later, he reported this to me and added, "When you get ready to add the sixth pastor, would you consider me?"

I responded by explaining, "It is because of the leading of the Holy Spirit." I said further, "Pastor Wurmbrand, you are already one of our pastors." We were supporting his mission already. Even now the church gives one percent of its income to his work and mission, Christian Missions to the Communist World, Inc.

Eight or nine years later Elizabeth Newby, author and wife of Dr. James Newby, volunteered that she had noticed a oneness in the staff at Scott Depot that she had not found anywhere else. There has only been one change in the pastoral staff, as far as full-time pastors are concerned, in the seventeen years that I have been at Scott Depot, and I am closer now in fellowship and love to that minister, Steven Reinhardt, of Hickory, North Carolina, than I have ever been. He served with me for about twelve years. Rod Taylor has served with me for fourteen years and is now the administrative pastor. He has complete charge of the pastoral ministry of the church, the Christian school and the day care. Visiting ministers are deeply moved over the love, devotion and enthusiasm of this associate minister who, when I found him, was an atheist. He was a radical socialist and a B. F. Skinner behaviorist who was deeply philosophical. Rod will soon receive his earned doctorate in Educational Administration. My father (known as Dad Hogue here) and David Anderson have ministered with me for eleven and ten years respectively. David Anderson is an ordained Southern Baptist minister with an excellent education from Southwestern Theological Seminary. When he came as my assistant, I never questioned him about the minutiae of his doctrine. We simply knew that we were called by God to walk together as we followed Christ. Rodney Dunn is in his third year with me at Scott Depot. Previously, he was an administrator of a large

nursing home. Besides these full-time men, I am assisted by two part-time assistant pastors and one lay pastor. Terry Richardson, our youth pastor, and Kathy Richardson Doss, his sister, have been a part of our ministerial staff for seven and six years respectively. Larry Hammett joined me ten years ago as lay pastor after leaving, because of God's direction, his business in Alabama. All of these pastors serve directly under Rod Taylor who has my full authority in all that he does. Because of the multiple ministries, especially the Christian school and day care, Scott Depot has a staff of more than fifty workers, thirty of which are full-time. I have gone into some detail in order to demonstrate the utter impossibility of oneness being evidenced here were it not for the leadership of the Holy Spirit. By God's grace, not one pastor has tried to undermine my senior position, nor have I ever been afraid to let them have the pulpit. I trust them to do their job without looking over their shoulders. Two great Christians, both qualified observers, registered the same observation nine years apart, that these ministers love me with a oneness unseen or unheard of anywhere in the world. The pastors have been willing to deny themselves in order to help me do God's will here and abroad. On the last trip to Israel, three of my assistant pastors traveled with me and paid their own way in order to take several persons who could not afford to pay. This has been done repeatedly.

I want to thank the Lord for giving me some of the finest ministers in Christendom. It was through the voice of God that all of them came to be with me. It is such an unusual report that I want the reader to take heart that God can begin and complete the task of oneness in any congregation. If He can make ministers and pastors visibly one,

He can do it with anyone. If He can be permitted to bring the ministers to oneness, He can do it for the congregation. Just think of the possibilities if all the pastors of the different churches could just get started on this road to oneness. We would have a revolution of righteousness before revival ever came. This is what Christ earnestly prayed for in His high priestly prayer. Even if only two or three in one place come to oneness, Christ will be in their presence and they may ask for what they will and it will be granted.

Again I say to you, if two of you agree on earth about anything they ask, it will be done for them by my Father in heaven. For where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I in the midst of them (Matthew 18:19,20).

The importance of these verses with reference to the achievement of oneness and its subsequent accomplishments are evident. If two or three persons are gathered in the name of Christ, He is in the midst of that group. A group cannot meet for worship in a given place unless Christ Himself gives that permission. They must then agree, or as the Greek suggests, agree by talking a thing over with Christ and then proceeding according to His will.³² Unless that criterion is met, the Church is not in that place. A group must have the direction of Christ concerning a pastor and the plan of meeting, and they must do all things by talking it over with Him. This will bring His presence in a special and gracious way resulting in a release of His power to bring about His will upon the earth.

One begins to see the explanation of the signs of renewal in the Scott Depot congregation. A congregation gathered at God's gracious

³²R. C. H. Lenski, The Interpretation Of St. Matthews Gospel, (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1964), p. 705.

invitation accepts the pastor and ministers commissioned by Him for that place. Then they proceed in worship, travel and related ministries to ask for and do only what Christ directs.

As the Church follows the leadership of the Holy Spirit, He takes them along a divinely predetermined way that leads to oneness which will help fulfill her mission. As a living sacrifice they do only God's will which will bring them to perfect oneness. Then through the power of the Holy Spirit, the glory of God will cover an entire area and convince all men of their selfishness and cause them to yield themselves to God.

The Holy Spirit has revealed the Scott Depot Christ Fellowship is not to strive for large numbers of people. In fact, in earlier years the Lord made it clear that if Scott Depot tried to become a very large church, she would virtually eliminate the possibility of becoming one with the Father and Son. I am aware that this revelation flies in the face of the pressure on the evangelical churches to become as big as possible by quickly winning many souls, but large numbers did not come to the Early Church until she had waited and had been baptized with the Holy Spirit. Large crowds started with Christ, but when He explained the way of commitment they nearly all fell away. He said to the Disciples, "Do you also wish to go away?" (John 6:67). Peter's answer must be ours: "Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life; and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God" (John 6:68,69).

Who would dare argue against people being spiritually converted? Nevertheless, we must seriously consider what we mean by conversion and what God means, and what He intends for those who would be truly

converted. Often times our evangelistic campaigns for souls are no more than occasions for people to be relieved of troublesome guilt. There can be a reciting of a few faith phrases followed by declaration of accepting God's forgiveness through grace, and that is the extent of the perception of spiritual need or the understanding of the call of Christ. The emphasis of Christ was not on conversion. The emphasis of Jesus was on following, on becoming disciples, on taking up the cross. The call is not simply to shallow conversion but to commitment. Unless God is doing the calling to Himself and His Kingdom by His Spirit (and when He calls it is a call to commitment and cross-bearing), the call is not genuine or spiritually fruitful. That call of God comes by and through a people of God who are abandoned to Him and emptied sufficiently of self so that the love and power of the Spirit of God can flow through that people to draw men to Christ and to commitment. A people so prepared and so used of God are equipped then to challenge and nurture those who are converted to the true life of a Christian, a life of divine love and triumphant surrender to the will of God. Large numbers being brought to a prayer of asking forgiveness cannot be the emphasis or the end of our Christian mission. The mission of the Church is to be one in purpose, commitment and love to such a degree that God is able to release His call by the Holy Spirit through His people to draw men to conversion and true discipleship. When someone is converted, he can only be challenged to discipleship through a body of believers who are walking in Christlikeness. That is why God usually draws people to Himself in large numbers only when a people of God are equipped to nurture them in real Christian living and challenge them to a joyful following of Christ in all things. New converts feed from the joy of

the Lord in the saints, and they are led onward by their spiritual victory and example. Men are not to be converted to the likeness of fleshly men but to the likeness of Christ. This likeness is revealed chiefly through a body of believers, a community of faith, living in the real, the vital, the dynamic Spirit and love of God. Often individual soul-winning campaigns are promoted, and Christians are taught the appropriate Scriptures and techniques to "lead" people to Christ. We are always to be thankful and to be testifying of God's help and goodness to us. But unless God is leading and God is doing the calling, then we are not leading people to God or genuine conversion by our techniques and strategies, but we are leading them to a fleshly experience that hardens them to a true call of God to follow Christ. Only God knows how much more harm than good has been done by men trying to "convert" others to Christ by their own strategies rather than letting God do the work by His Spirit. It is not in large numbers of shallow-experience conversions but in spiritual oneness that we recognize and take hope in God's work. God wants to draw all men to Himself. He does it when He is lifted up by a group of people who have humbled themselves and who have become nothing in order to experience a cross which results in a resurrection as the body of the living Christ.

Throughout history large numbers have never flocked to the cross. The true cross is an instrument of death upon which self is crucified. Salvation or genuine faith is objective and subjective. The curse of contemporary evangelical Christianity is the shallow perception and experience of the cross. The cross of Jesus not only crucified Him, it crucifies everyone who takes it up. Faith is intrinsically commitment. When we rely on the Lord for everything, it begins with

salvation and it continues with a life of sanctification. But faith is always an option. As free moral agents in this life, we never lose the choice of being committed or not being committed. It is a rare thing to find anyone who will lay down his own life and follow only God's will. Still rarer is a church who will do the same. God has always called for a company, not a person, to be a living sacrifice. Only in community-death can a work be produced through resurrection power that proves that Jesus has been sent by the Father for the salvation of all. Love for one another proves that we are His disciples, but our death to self-will proves that He is the Christ. We must love God enough to choose Him forever in all things. That is strategy enough. And it is the best strategy. It is the only way to fulfill our mission.

The chief obstacle to the Church's mission being fulfilled is the lack of individual and corporate denial of the self-will. The missing link in our individual and community life as far as faith is concerned is self-denial. We must individually and corporately choose God's will. Individual choices, of course, will involve the home. Homes become alive with the power and love of God when fathers, mothers, brothers and sisters choose to put God's will first. Such committed families will, in turn, be foundational and contributive to the corporate choice of the Church to do God's will.

Early in my ministry at Scott Depot, the Lord witnessed that the church should hold a series of services on a certain date. That week of services came at a time when the local high school played its chief rival. Naturally, it stirred more interest than most other games. The Lord had revealed the meeting was His will, so I announced that I expected all of those professing Jesus as Lord to be at church. I

really did not realize the depth of interest in the football game, but it would not have changed my challenge to the people if I had known. If it were, indeed, God's will that our fellowship have these services, then that meant that the living God would be with us and wanted to do some spiritual work for our community of faith. It would take our fellowship's unified and single-purpose response to claim this work of God. God was interested in us as a community of believers striving for His will together. Only as we heard Him call and responded together, would we get to His perfect will as a unified, committed company. The week of services began on Monday, and the attendance was good. As I remember, most of the congregation were there every night, including the night of the big game. The following Sunday I was thrilled with the faithfulness of the people and, having been filled in on what an important choice they had made, I responded with enthusiasm by complimenting the church. Then I threw down the gauntlet by declaring, "Any one who chooses football over the Bride of Christ chooses hell over Heaven." To do God's will, the mission of the Bride of Christ, must always be our first and only choice. Sunday afternoon a leading member called me on the phone and proceeded to tell me that I had placed a number of people in a bad light because they had chosen to go to the football game. He expressed that it would be a wise thing for me to retract that statement. In fact, he said that if I did not retract it, he would personally see that I was run out of town. I hardly knew what to say, but I could not back down. I had not meant to place these persons in a bad light, so I promised to speak to the issue in some way.

When I arrived at the sanctuary that night, I still did not know what to say or do. Somewhere in the service the Lord was gracious to

give me revelation and inspiration. I realized that anything I would say would only cause me to compromise the Lordship of Christ or get me in deeper trouble with those who would not understand. So I called on a man who was a known sinner and asked him to stand and comment on what I had said in the morning service about football and the Bride of Christ. He stood right up and spoke forthrightly, "Pastor, if you don't keep preaching that way, we are all going to go to hell." Two more men who made no profession backed up the first spokesman. The man who opposed me jumped up and left the meeting. In a few minutes a few more people left with him; everyone else stayed.

Although my knees shook and the small minority caused quite a storm, God helped me to love and stand firm. My father had taught me not to stir up more devils than I could whip, so I did not fan the flames anymore about that issue. The church stood firm in humility and love, and we passed the test of commitment to the will of God. By God's grace, the congregation has been passing the test ever since. Perhaps I could have been more gracious in my declaration that Sunday, but what I said could not be compromised once it was spoken. If we choose anything of this world (good or bad) over the will of God, we choose hell over Heaven. God's will is not only our place of safety, it is our way to mission--the mission of demonstrating and declaring the reign of God to all men.

Total commitment on the part of any church is surely an unfulfilled dream, but the call and the possibility is still there. It happened once in history and can happen again because God has not changed nor have the requirements. The way to that dream is through a wilderness, a wilderness through which few men have ever made their way.

We need a voice in that wilderness to guide us through. Essentially, that voice has to be the voice of the Eternal God. "True life comes from the words that God speaks" (Matthew 4:4b NCV). Unless we stop the noise of our own activity and planning, we cannot hear what God is saying. God has never left us without light in any generation. He has always given us men who follow Him. If we cannot follow God ourselves (hardly any can at first), we must follow that person or persons who are hearing and following the voice of God. The cry of the Prophet Hosea has been the cry of the Holy Spirit for over two thousand years: "Let us pursue obedience to the Lord, And we shall become obedient. His appearance is as sure as daybreak, And He will come to us like rain, like latter rain that refreshes the earth" (Hosea 6:3 JPS).

Several years ago I attended a series of religious services held in Indianapolis, Indiana, which were truly meetings of "waiting upon God." The evangelist Loran Helm was following the leadership of the Holy Spirit for the program of the service. Each hymn, testimony, prayer, Scripture and special song was wonderful. The joy of the Lord was upon the congregation. Loran Helm's sharing and teaching had greatly encouraged the listeners, and Heaven seemed very near. I remember that he called on the music minister of that church to sing a number from his list of selections which God had revealed. Of course Loran did not know what it was going to be nor did the congregants. The song was entitled "In This Very Room." The words were as follows:

In this very room there's quite enough love for one like me,
 And in this very room there's quite enough joy for one like me,
 And there's quite enough hope and quite enough power to chase
 away any gloom,
 For Jesus, Lord Jesus is in this very room.

And in this very room there's quite enough love for all of us.
 And in this very room there's quite enough joy for all of us,
 And there's quite enough hope and quite enough power to chase
 away any gloom.
 For Jesus, Lord Jesus is in this very room.

And in this very room there's quite enough love for all the
 world.
 And in this very room there's quite enough joy for all the
 world.
 And there's quite enough hope and quite enough power to chase
 away any gloom,
 For Jesus, Lord Jesus is in this very room.³³

The presence of the Lord had been wonderful up until that moment, but the perfect timing of the song, with the appropriate words that described the essence and possibility of that particular service, coupled with an anointing that could only come from God Himself deepened the sense of His presence. We experienced a moment of Holy Communion, perhaps most appropriately illustrated by the best loved of all Quaker paintings, The Presence in the Midst by Doyle Penrose. The painting shows a group of seated Quakers with heads humbly bowed in worship. Above the heads of the worshippers, the artist has painted the person of Christ with arms outstretched, depicting the reality of the presence of Christ in true worship.

Somewhere in the flow of the service, I heard Loran pray, "Oh, Lord, how long has it been since you were able to lead a service like this? Has it been one hundred, two hundred, or three hundred years?" The Holy Spirit witnessed, "Three hundred years." I began trying to remember what happened in the seventeenth century that was really of God. Was there a group of people in that century who waited on the Lord

³³ "In This Very Room" Copyright 1979, Ron Harris Music, Used by permission.

to actually hear Him speak and then to follow? I could remember the Wesleyan revival of the eighteenth century and the Reformation led by Luther in the sixteenth century, but somehow I could not remember anything about the seventeenth century. Upon my return home, I opened my seminary history text and to my surprise found that it had almost no reference to anything of significance in the seventeenth century. But, ironically, the atheistic philosophers and historians, Will and Ariel Durant, in their acclaimed work, The Story of Civilization, detail the revival of experiential and vital Christianity in several groups.³⁴ Notable among the various groups were the Quietists of Italy and the Quakers of England. They sought to hear the voice of God within and to follow the will of God. Consequently, form and ritual were never substituted for an experience with the living Christ. They always endeavored to follow the leadings of the Holy Spirit no matter what the cost. A number of Quakers and Quietists paid the cost of imprisonment and death.

Several days after my research had ended, I was talking with Loran on the telephone. I reminded him that the Holy Spirit had witnessed that three hundred years ago there had been meetings led by the Holy Spirit like those experienced in Indianapolis. After explaining what I had found in my research, I asked him if the Lord was leading in the Quakers or the Catholic Quietists or both. He responded that the Holy Spirit witnessed on both. Several months later, I heard with astonishment the words of Elton Trueblood after I had shared the

³⁴Will & Ariel Durant, The Story Of Civilization, VIII (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1963).

story of Scott Depot Christ Fellowship. He said, "What you have at Scott Depot is not Quakerism but seventeenth century Quakerism."

Dr. Trueblood, a Quaker himself and writer of a history of The People Called Quakers, as well as many other books, had recognized the same reality to which the Holy Spirit had witnessed: a group of people like the Quakers of the seventeenth century were genuinely trying to wait upon God in holy dependence. Such waiting upon the Lord was not only to feel the Lord's presence but to hear His voice so that through His wisdom and guidance the love, joy and power of that "presence in the midst" might reach the entire world.

Somehow the writer of the song "In This Very Room" had captured not only the essence of worship but the possibility and power for getting the Kingdom of God to the whole world. The mission reconceived in the seventeenth century must not be aborted now. The mission for which God has so long sought a people to fulfill must become the focus, the very life of the Church once again. How tragic, how ironic that the Church which has sought long and, at times, feverishly for a strategy to bring God's Kingdom by its own devices has, by these very devices, missed its mission. This mission cannot be fulfilled by the strategies and means of men. This mission can only be realized by the power and wisdom and love of God made manifest to a company of people committed to God's will without reservation. This magnificent mission must be accomplished. This daring dream must be fulfilled. This call must be answered.